

Open-Source KNIGHTS

A Streamlined TTRPG for Crafting
Bespoke Heroes

Lead Designer: Chris Comstock
Lead Contributor: Michelle Dickey
Contributor / Logo Design: Dani Comstock

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Chapter 1: Introduction

TL;DR / WHAT IS OSK?

- Open-Source Knights is a TTRPG framework built from a foundation of D&D 5E. It prioritizes streamlined gameplay and flexibility in character design.
- OSK can be thought of either as a standalone TTRPG, OR as a package of rule modifications for improving character creation and combat in D&D 5E.
- OSK emphasizes fast, tactical combat with a focused, quickly scannable set of immediately-available options, rather than requiring players to navigate dozens of options every turn.
- In OSK, a character's abilities are designed by the players themselves, in collaboration with each other and with the Game Master.
- You can customize your abilities to suit your own preferences, whether you like simplicity, narrative flourish, tactical depth, or any combination thereof.
- OSK provides a common mechanical language to allow players to adapt character features from entirely separate TTRPG systems, such as Draw Steel, Daggerheart, or Pathfinder.
- Like many TTRPGs, OSK adopts a "rulings, not rules" mindset. Common sense and intuition take priority over having a rule for every possible situation.
- OSK is built to be very approachable to TTRPG beginners, while enabling maximum creativity for experienced players.

MY FIRST D&D CAMPAIGN

I've been a board game enthusiast for most of my life, but Dungeons & Dragons had never been on my radar until around 2018. Four years after the release of D&D 5E, and roughly around the time that Critical Role and Stranger Things began gaining steam – I had started seeing articles about how "There's never been a better time to learn how to play D&D!" So I played a few tutorial sessions with friends, and with volunteer DMs at a local board game convention, and it clicked almost immediately: *"OHHH! D&D is a cross between a board game and a Star Trek holodeck, if the holodeck ran purely on human imagination!"* After binge-watching most of the first Critical Role campaign, I began to think: "Actually, I bet I COULD be a DM like Matt Mercer.....you know, just in my own simplified style, and without the *overwhelming dramatic panache* he brings to the game."

Then in 2020, COVID hit. While isolated in our homes and in search of something fun and cheerful to do during all the dystopian misery, I decided I would start running the game, online, for some friends and family who graciously agreed to be my medieval-fantasy guinea pigs. My first D&D campaign ever ended up lasting five years, with all of the same players and characters, and ending with the characters at Level 20. I didn't know just how rare a feat this was until after we had completed the campaign, but learning that made me think that I must be doing SOMETHING right.

JUNKY DESIGN

Suffice it to say, I learned a lot during that first campaign. But many of my top takeaways were related to what veteran game designer Matt Colville describes as D&D's "junky design". The process of creating a character and then advancing them to 20th level is excruciatingly convoluted. Combat in the 12-20th level range of D&D is an infamously miserable slog, due to the Cheesecake-Factory-menu-sized list of options that every character has available to them at that point – and players either spend several minutes every turn picking out exactly what slice of cheesecake they want, or are so overwhelmed by the menu that they just pick the same slice over, and over, and over, and over again. "30 minutes of fun crammed into 3 hours." Not to mention all the monotonous bookkeeping required at that point.

D&D Beyond – the website that offers a toolkit for building characters and managing their sheets online – really only shifts this bookkeeping from paper to pixel form, as any group who has had to sit through the rigmarole of "One second, I know my character has this feature....I think....just let me see if I can find it....sorry....what tab is it on?I think it's a druid thing....just a second....hang on...." can tell you.

I quickly learned that these types of grumbles over D&D's design were fairly widespread. The TTRPG YouTube channel *Deficient Master* touched on many of these types of problems in his video "*Your D&D Character Builds SUCK. This is why.*" The entire video resonated with me, but two points in particular: first, why is it that as soon as combat begins in D&D, players tend to stop thinking about the "imagination-holodeck" of the game world and instead tunnel-vision onto only the "paper buttons" that their character sheet says they can push? And second, why does D&D combat feel like a video game, but with extra (and significantly more boring) steps, such as manually crunching all the numbers involved?

The manifold problems inherent to D&D's design led me to the wider TTRPG industry (and community), to see how other DMs and games were doing things differently. The Wizards of the Coast OGL scandal of early 2022 – the details of which I'll leave you to look up on your own – proved to be a major turning point. Ultimately, the OGL scandal led to (or at the very least, preceded) a new wave of TTRPGs and TTRPG products, including *Daggerheart*, by Critical Role's Darrington Press; *Shadowdark*, by Kelsey Dionne / Arcane Library, and (my personal favorite) *Draw Steel*, by Matt Colville, James Introcaso, and everyone else over at MCDM. The latter was of particular importance: MCDM shared much of the process of developing *Draw Steel* openly, via YouTube, their Discord server, and their Patreon. Though I am a software engineer by trade, rather than a game designer – I've always had a love for homebrewing and modifying my favorite board games to make them more fun. And watching *Draw Steel*'s development made me ask: "I wonder if I could do that...?"

FORGE OF HEROES

Although unrelated to the OGL scandal, Mike Shea (aka "Sly Flourish") published his "Forge of Foes" book in 2023. The brilliance of this book is that it stripped monster/enemy design down to its bare essentials, and gave DMs a quick-reference menu for building combatants that were far more streamlined and easier to use than the offerings in the D&D Monster Manual. The thought occurred to me that, if I were to design a TTRPG, I could solve many of D&D's problems by making it a "reverse Forge of Foes" – a "Forge of Heroes", so to speak.

Because D&D is the most widely-known TTRPG by orders of magnitude, and because its System Reference Document was released under the Creative Commons license as a *mea culpa* after the OGL scandal, I knew I wanted this new game to start

with D&D 5E as its underlying framework. But I also knew I wanted to strip out all of the "junky design" that made it such a slog to play in aspects such as high-level combat. Combat needed to be streamlined – the menu of options available to a player on their turn should be short, clear, and meaningful. Shadowdark's beautiful simplicity proved to be an invaluable example for how to do this. Then I wanted to solve the "Cheesecake Factory menu" problem – D&D players had to sift through so much material for their characters, how can we make things easier for them to find without resorting to dozens of tabs of tiny text (à la D&D Beyond)? Daggerheart's card system seemed like a brilliant solution: keep all of the players' abilities right there in front of them, and keep them simple enough to fit on a small card.

But what about the "paper buttons" problem? The thing that makes TTRPGs so thrilling is that they're powered as much by creativity and imagination as they are by a defined rule set. Eventually it clicked: *let the players be the ones to design their own paper buttons!* The hard part here, of course, is ensuring that said buttons are balanced in terms of gameplay. But to quote TTRPG designer Joey Haeck on an episode of The Eldritch Lorecast, "the only balance that really matters is between the players"; because the DM is the one building the encounters, any semblance of balance between the DM and the players is ultimately a degree of "smoke and mirrors". This new game needed to provide a framework for allowing character ability design as a player-facing mechanic. But how can we pair that with Daggerheart's elegant "card" solution? By taking a page out of Index Card RPG's design and using, well, index cards!

Solving D&D's mechanical problems is one thing, but what should the game really FEEL like? Well, people already hack and homebrew the heck out of D&D to make it fit all sorts of different genres, from folk-heroic to dungeon-delving to survival-horror to eldritch-nightmare to epic-fantasy-

superhero. Matt Colville describes this as "oatmeal" design: oatmeal can be tasty, but is kind of bland and uninspired unless you really make an effort to *zhuzh* it up. That's why Draw Steel is less "oatmeal" and more "vanilla-bean Belgian waffles with a blackberry reduction and delicate crème fraîche quenelle". But I concluded that D&D's more (ostensibly) amorphous nature is more of a benefit than a drawback for the kind of game I wanted to design. I want to give players a stack of pancakes, and then give them an explicit method for adding whatever toppings they want (within reason!). So I guess now we're a Star Trek holodeck with a replicator built into it? But unleashing player creativity is arguably the main thing that sets TTRPGs apart from every other type of game in existence. For this game, that unleashed creativity is tempered by rules and guidelines that enable the players themselves to design character abilities that are, to quote veteran TTRPG designer Shawn Merwin, The Three F's: *"Fun, Flavorful, and F***ing Balanced!"*

A TTRPG API

While developing the game, a thought occurred to me. If players are meant to design abilities for their characters, why not let them "import" concepts (including character classes and species) wholesale from other systems? If the framework and boundaries of this new game are functioning properly, then – at least in theory – there's no reason that a D&D 5E Wizard, a Daggerheart Seraph, a Draw Steel Tactician, and a Pathfinder Alchemist couldn't all be in the same party.

Here, I was able to draw on my experience as a software engineer. Wildly different software systems are still able to communicate with each other, provided that they communicate using a shared Application Programming Interface (or API). I began to realize that this worked as a analogue for what was possible with the new game system. It could use D&D 5E as the basis for an "API" that lets players

import all sorts of stuff – provided they followed the rules, and fit each imported piece onto an index card.

But this level of freedom quickly led me to discover one of the game's main tradeoffs.

COMMUNICATE OR DIE

Communication between a Game Master and all of the players at the table is critical to ensuring any TTRPG campaign functions smoothly. If the players want a cozy campaign where the only combat is to protect shipments of ingredients to the bakery they're running, the GM would be way out of line to have Brutalicus Maximus, a torture-loving eldritch horror, burst through the bakery's front door (unless he's just there to buy cookies).

But the wide-open nature of this new game would require an even greater level of communication between everyone at the table. If everyone has agreed to participate in a medieval-fantasy game, you don't want a player to build a character with a sci-fi class who specializes in antimatter rifles. (Fun fact: antimatter rifles are a real piece of equipment as defined by the 2014 D&D Dungeon Master's Guide. They're even listed as an option on D&D Beyond.)

But because the new game relies so much on custom content (and the GM's ability to adjudicate said content), the players and GM would all have to agree on things such as permitted source material, campaign tone, ability complexity, and balance expectations before character creation even began. The group should come to an agreement on how freely abilities could be drawn from various different systems. It would be the players' responsibility to design abilities in good faith, aiming to support the group rather than deliberately trying to exploit gaps in the rules. The GM would ultimately have the final authority over whether player-designed

abilities were appropriate for the setting and style of the game. And if the GM raised any concerns about designed content, they should explain the concerns, and the player(s) should work on revising them. In general, ability design is not be a one-and-done situation – everyone should expect a degree of revision and "settling" as the group actually uses the things they have designed for their characters in the game. While the rules of moment-to-moment gameplay and combat are significantly streamlined, the fundamental tradeoff is that the complexity has shifted to player-driven ability design. (And this, in turn, would necessitate a large number of "built-in" example cards.)

CORE DESIGN GOALS

I started designing the game by consolidating its development around some core design principles:

- Fast, readable combat: Combat should move quickly, with clear choices and minimal interruption.
- Flexible character construction: Players can build characters around their concepts instead of rigid class packages.
- Low resource-tracking overhead: A small number of universally-shared systems replace numerous separate resources (such as spell slots, sorcery points, ki points, etc).
- Player-created abilities: Players shape their characters by designing abilities through collaboration with the GM and the rest of the table.

- Easy conversion of outside material: Abilities and concepts from other TTRPGs can be adapted into the game.
- GM judgment over exhaustive rules: The GM uses common sense and table consensus when no specific rule applies.
- What to leave out: Rather than building elaborate bespoke systems for activities such as travel, downtime, crafting, negotiation, exploration, or encumbrance, they are simply handled through ordinary in-game fiction, dice rolls, and GM adjudication.
- System modularity: Design the game so that its major systems remain relatively decoupled from one another, making it easier for groups to modify or replace individual mechanics.

The rest of this book is about turning those principles into concrete rules for characters, cards, combat, and ability design.

First, build the hero. Then go kick the villain's ass.
-Chris

Chapter 2: If You Are New To TTRPGs

WHAT IS A TTRPG?

- A tabletop roleplaying game is a shared storytelling game.
- Each player controls a character in an imagined world.
- One player takes the role of the Game Master.
- The rules and dice help determine what happens when the outcome is uncertain.

THE GAME MASTER

- The Game Master describes the world, its inhabitants, and the situations the characters encounter.
- The Game Master controls enemies, monsters, and other non-player characters.
- The Game Master decides when a dice roll is necessary.
- The Game Master interprets the rules and makes rulings when no exact rule applies.
- The Game Master is not the players' opponent. Their goal is to present interesting situations and help everyone create an enjoyable game.

THE PLAYERS

- Each player controls one main character.
- You describe what your character says, thinks, and attempts to do.
- You do not need to speak "in character" unless you want to.
- You are encouraged to ask questions about the situation before making decisions.
- Your character can attempt anything that makes sense, even if it is not explicitly on their character sheet or their cards.

THE BASIC FLOW OF PLAY

- The Game Master describes the situation.
- The players ask questions and describe what their characters do.
- The Game Master determines the results.
- Dice are rolled if the outcome is uncertain.
- The situation changes, and the process repeats.

THE FICTION COMES FIRST

- Always describe what your character is trying to accomplish. The rules are used to resolve that action.
- You do not necessarily need to name a specific Skill or game mechanic before describing what you do.
- The Game Master decides which rule or roll best fits the situation.

WHEN TO ROLL DICE

- Dice are rolled when an action could meaningfully succeed or fail.
- Trivially easy actions, or actions where the outcome is certain, usually do not require a roll.
- Impossible actions usually cannot be achieved by any roll at all.
- The Game Master tells you what dice to roll and which modifier to add.

CHECKS

- A "Check" determines how well your character performs an uncertain task.
- Most checks are resolved with a standard procedure: roll a d20, add the relevant modifier, and compare the total to a Difficulty Class.
- The Difficulty Class is a number chosen by the DM that represents how challenging the task is to accomplish.
- If the total meets or exceeds the Difficulty Class, the Check succeeds.
- A higher result may produce a better outcome at the Game Master's discretion.
- Typically, rolling a 20 on the d20 (called a "Natural 20") means an exceptionally good result on your character's part (narratively, mechanically, or both).
- Conversely, rolling a 1 on the d20 (a "Natural 1") may mean an exceptionally poor result, at the GM's discretion.

ATTRIBUTES AND SKILLS

- Attributes describe your character's broad physical and mental capabilities.
- There are six attributes: Strength, Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma.
- Skills describe their training in more specific areas.
- The Game Master decides whether an Attribute, Skill, or another modifier applies to a roll.
- Your character sheet lists the modifiers you add.

PLAYING YOUR CHARACTER

- Consider what your character wants and how they usually approach problems.
- You are not required to make the most efficient decision.
- Mistakes, risks, and unusual choices can make the game more interesting.
- Your character may disagree with other characters, but players should continue cooperating with each other.

WORKING AS A GROUP

- TTRPGs are cooperative games. Give other players room to speak and make decisions.
- Avoid deliberately disrupting the game or preventing others from participating.
- Share information your character would reasonably communicate.
- Help create opportunities for every character to contribute.

ASKING QUESTIONS

- You are always allowed to ask what your character can see, hear, know, or reasonably understand.
- You may ask the Game Master to clarify a rule or situation.
- If you are unsure what to do, ask the group for suggestions.
- Calling a Timeout pauses play so the group can resolve confusion or discomfort.

FAILURE

- Failure does not mean you played incorrectly.
- A failed roll may introduce danger, complications, lost time, or difficult choices.
- Failure should usually move the situation forward rather than stop the game entirely.
- Characters are expected to face setbacks.

COMBAT

- Combat begins when the Game Master determines that turn-by-turn action is necessary.
- Combat uses a grid, Initiative, Actions, Ability cards, and other rules described later in this book.
- On your turn, decide what your character is trying to accomplish and use your Actions accordingly.
- You may ask other players for help understanding your options.

YOU DO NOT NEED TO KNOW EVERYTHING

- You are not expected to memorize the entire rulebook.
- Learn the basic rules that apply to your character and refer to the book when necessary.
- More experienced players may help explain rules, but the Game Master makes the final ruling.
- The best way to learn OSK is by playing.

Chapter 3: If You Are Coming From D&D 5E

OSK IS A D&D-5E-ADJACENT FRAMEWORK

- Open-Source Knights is built primarily from the concepts and structure of D&D 5E.
- However, it modifies or replaces many of D&D's character-building, combat, and resource-management rules.
- Many familiar terms remain, but they may function differently.
- When OSK and D&D rules conflict, use the OSK rule.

CHARACTERS AND CLASSES

- Most characters have one Primary Class and one Secondary Class.
- Characters gain levels in both Classes simultaneously.
- Classes do not grant a fixed list of features at every level; rather, they define the types of Abilities a character may create.
- There are no subclasses, though players are free to create Abilities based on Source Abilities from relevant subclasses.
- OSK does not use Backgrounds as a separate mechanical character feature.
- A character's history, occupation, and culture remain part of their backstory, but do not automatically grant Skills or features.

ABILITY CARDS

- Class features, spells, maneuvers, and similar effects are represented by Ability cards.
- These Ability cards are player-created, and are generally represented by 3x5 index cards.
- This book contains a set of "default" OSK cards, but players are highly encouraged to design their own.
- Player-created abilities are called "Designed Abilities", and are usually based on a corresponding "Source Ability" from one of the character's Classes.
- A Designed Ability should preserve its Source Ability's fantasy, function, or both - but it does not need to preserve its exact mechanics.

ATTRIBUTES AND SKILLS

- OSK uses the six familiar Attributes: STR, DEX, CON, INT, WIS, and CHA.
- Attributes are recorded as modifiers rather than scores.
- Skills (Animal Handling, Stealth, etc) are not permanently linked to specific Attributes.
- OSK does not use a Perception Skill. The Game Master should freely describe anything a character can plainly see, hear, smell, or otherwise notice.
- Hidden dangers and concealed information may involve Skills such as Investigation, Insight, or Survival.
- The Persuasion Skill represents a character's minimum competence in social influence.
- A Persuasion modifier is the "floor" that a corresponding Persuasion check should add at minimum.
- However, if a player employs strong reasoning or skilled roleplaying, the GM should grant a higher modifier, as appropriate.
- Note that even a very high Persuasion Check does not force another character to behave irrationally.

COMBAT IN BRIEF

- Combat in OSK assumes the use of a gridded map.
- Initiative is team-based, and play alternates between the Player Team and the Enemy Team.
- Abilities, Equipment, and Consumables are represented by cards.
- Only cards in the character's current Loadout are immediately available during combat.
- Most Ability cards (and certain Equipment cards) enter the Cooldown Queue after being used.
- The Cooldown Queue replaces many resources such as spell slots, superiority dice, Ki points, and sorcery points.
- Critical Hits and Critical Misses in combat function a bit differently than D&D 5E.
- See the Combat chapter for the complete rules.

THE ACTION ECONOMY

- Each character takes three Actions on their turn. OSK does not divide a turn into an Action, Bonus Action, and Movement.
- A character may take the same action type up to twice on a turn.
- However, only one card can be placed into the Cooldown Queue per turn.
- Additionally, some cards can have a "Combo" property, which allows them to be played into Cooldown Slot 1 simultaneously with another card.
- OSK does not use a universal "Reaction".
- A character may instead Hold an Action and define an off-turn Trigger for it.
- OSK also does not use Attacks of Opportunity or a Disengage action.
- Specific Abilities may still create between-turn effects or restrict enemy movement.

DAMAGE AND WEAPONS

- OSK primarily uses d6s for damage.
- Ordinary weapons do not have separate universal damage dice. Rather, damage is primarily determined by the Ability being used.
- Ability damage is organized into five Damage Tiers, for balancing purposes.
- Physical damage combines bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing into one category of Damage Type.
- Unusual or powerful weapons may have their own Equipment cards.

ARMOR CLASS

- Each team shares a single Armor Class. Player AC is based on the team's current Level.
- A roll below Armor Class does not usually mean a complete miss. Many Abilities have a weaker "Under-AC" result and a stronger "Over-AC" result.
- A character's standard armor is considered "built into" the default party AC.
- Special armor may have its own Equipment card, but this should generally raise the character's HP instead of adjusting AC.

OTHER IMPORTANT DIFFERENCES

- Advantage and Disadvantage can stack into Double Advantage and Double Disadvantage (roll 3 d20s and use the highest/lowest).
- Advantage and Disadvantage cancel each other one step at a time.
- A character may hold up to 5 Inspiration Points, which can be used to reroll failed Checks or Attack Rolls.
- Short Rests do not exist, and a Long Rest (also simply called a Rest) usually lasts 8-12 hours.
- Healing is limited by Recovery Points rather than Hit Dice or Spell Slots.
- Any time a character recovers HP between Long Rests, no matter the amount, they spend a Recovery Point.
- A dying character may still be stabilized even if they have no remaining Recovery Points.
- Resting restores all HP and Recovery Points.

RULINGS OVER RULES

- OSK intentionally gives the Game Master broad authority. Intuition and common sense trump having an explicit rule for every situation.
- Custom Abilities, Wildcard Actions, and unusual situations rely on judgment rather than exhaustive procedures.
- The Game Master may revise a rule or custom card that proves unclear, disruptive, or unbalanced.
- Players and the Game Master should approach these decisions collaboratively.

WHAT DO I NEED TO PLAY?

- Like in most pen-and-paper TTRPGs, characters are represented primarily by their character sheet.
- The character sheet records your character's stats, such as Attributes (STR/DEX/CON/INT/WIS/CHA), Skills, health (Hit Points), and other essential information.
- However, all character abilities (such as species traits, fighting maneuvers, and spells) are all represented on 3x5 notecards, created by the player.

WHAT TYPES OF DICE DOES OSK USE?

- OSK uses: a d20, ten d6, and a d100 (typically represented by a d10 and a percentile die)
- OSK DOES NOT use: d4s, d8s, or d12s

TIMEOUT:

- At any point during the game, any player (including the GM) can call a Timeout.
- During a Timeout, gameplay immediately pauses, and all players break character and discuss the situation out of game.
- Timeouts can be used to ask questions and get clarifications as necessary.
- Timeouts can also be used if a situation in the game is making a player feel uncomfortable out of game.
- When the issue or question has been resolved to everyone's satisfaction, gameplay resumes as usual.

CHARACTER SHEET AND CARDS:

- The sheet represents most of the characteristics that make up your character.
- Several areas of the sheet have circular pips that represent things like Experience, Attributes, Recovery Points, etc. These pips are always bubbled in from left-to-right.
- Your character's species, abilities, equipment, and supplies are represented by a deck of 3x5 notecards that you create as you build your character.
- You create additional cards as your character adventures and gains experience and new equipment.

CARD TYPES:

- There are four types of cards in OSK.
- Species - a card that represents the traits of your character's species.
- Abilities - a card that represents a character's combat maneuver, spell, or other feature.
- Equipment - a card that represents a piece of equipment, such as a special weapon or tool.
- Consumable - a single-use card, such as a potion. It is removed from your deck after it is used.
- It is recommended that you assign a color for each type of card.
- OSK's default coloring is: Species/Red, Ability/Blue, Equipment/Green, Consumable/Purple.

DECK & LOADOUT:

- Your "Deck" is all of the 3x5 cards your character has available to them.
- There is no limit on the number of cards you can have in your deck.
- Your "Loadout" is a subset of 10 cards that your character has access to on your turn in combat.
- Note: Your character's Species card is always available to you, but it DOES NOT count against your Loadout's 10-card limit.
- The purpose of the Loadout is to prevent excessive cognitive load on players.
- Outside of combat, you can swap cards between your Deck and Loadout at will, as often as you want.
- To swap cards between your Deck and Loadout after combat has begun, you must take the Reconfigure action (see Chapter XX).

HIT POINTS:

- Your character's Hit Points (HP) represent how far they are from death.
- As your character takes wounds and sustains injuries their HP decreases.
- However, HP does not necessarily represent only wounds - it can also represent the stamina a character has left to avoid fatal blows.
- HP can be regained via the application of first aid, medicine, potions, healing spells, etc.
- Once your character's HP reaches 0, they fall unconscious and must begin making Death Saving Throws.

DEATH / DEATH SAVING THROWS:

- To make a Death Saving Throw, simply roll a d20 and add nothing. If the roll is 10 or greater, mark one success. If the roll is 9 or less, mark one failure.
- During combat, a dying character must make a Death Saving Throw after EVERY time a Player Team turn concludes.
- If a character takes damage while they are dying, they automatically fail one additional death save.
- If your character succeeds on 3 Death Saving Throws, they "stabilize" and regain 1 HP (this does not cost Recovery Points, and a character can stabilize even if they are out of Recovery Points).
- If your character fails 3 Death Saving Throws, they die.
- Depending on the circumstances of your game and campaign, you may be able to resurrect them.
- If resurrection is not possible, it's time to create a new character!

TEMPORARY HIT POINTS:

- Temporary HP represents a short-lived buffer against damage.
- Taking damage reduces your Temporary HP before reducing your normal HP.
- Temporary HP cannot be restored through healing.
- Multiple effects that grant Temporary HP can be stacked, but you cannot stack the same effect multiple times.
- Temporary HP usually disappears after a Long Rest, or when the effect granting it ends.

RECOVERY POINTS:

- Your character can regain lost HP by application of first aid, medicines, potions, healing spells, etc.
- Every character is capable of healing themselves and others, by using First Aid: make a Medicine check and using the result as the amount of HP restored.
- Every time your character regains any amount of HP, you mark one Recovery Point off your character sheet.
- Every character has 10 Recovery Points. When these are exhausted, your character can no longer regain HP until they rest.
- However, a character without any Recovery Points can still be stabilized (brought up to 1 HP) if they are dying.
- Certain rare consumables can allow characters to regain Recovery Points between rests.
- Resting restores all 10 of a character's Recovery Points.

RESTING:

- A Long Rest (also called a "Respite" or simply a "Rest") is an 8-12 hour period where your character does little more than sleep.
- Resting restores all of a character's HP, as well as all of their Recovery Points. It also removes the "Fatigued" condition.
- Note: There are no "short rests" - resting requires a minimum of 8 hours for most characters.

DAMAGE TYPES:

- Damage from abilities/equipment/etc is categorized by type:
- PhysicalSlashing, piercing, or bludgeoning damage
- AcidDamage from corrosive liquids
- ColdIce and frost effects, hypothermia
- FireDamage from heat, combustion, and certain types of explosions
- LightningElectricity-based damage, whether natural or artificial
- NecroticSapping a creature's life force, causing decay
- PoisonVenomous stings and toxic gases
- PsychicPsionic attacks, psychological manipulation, or extreme exertions of willpower
- RadiantDamage inflicted by holy energy or divine light
- SonicDamage from concussive blasts and loud sounds

DAMAGE VULNERABILITY / RESISTANCE / IMMUNITY:

- Some creatures take greater or lesser amounts of damage from attacks, based on the damage type.
- Vulnerability - A creature takes double damage of the specified type
- Resistance - A creature takes half damage of the specified type
- Immunity - A creature takes no damage of the specified type

FALL DAMAGE:

- A creature in an uncontrolled fall takes 1d6 of Physical damage for every 10ft they fall, upon impact.

SKILL CHECKS:

- Often, the GM will call for a Skill Check to determine how your character performs at a given task.
- These are typically resolved by rolling a d20, and adding your modifier for that skill.
- The total of this roll is compared to a "Difficulty Class".
- The Difficulty Class is a number determined by the GM that corresponds with the difficulty of the task your character is attempting.

ADVANTAGE & DISADVANTAGE:

- Sometimes, a particularly beneficial situation will grant advantage on a check or attack.
- To roll with advantage, roll two d20s and use the higher of the two when adding your modifier.
- Conversely, a negative effect or especially challenging situation will inflict disadvantage on a check.
- To roll with disadvantage, roll two d20s and use the lower of the two.

STACKING ADVANTAGE / DISADVANTAGE:

- If more than one beneficial circumstances converge to influence a check, you roll with double-advantage.
- For double-advantage, roll three d20s and take the highest.
- Conversely, with multiple problematic circumstances, you roll with double-disadvantage (roll three d20s and take the lowest).
- Advantage and disadvantage cancel each other out, one step at a time.
- For example, if a situation that normally grants double-advantage occurs simultaneously with a situation that grants disadvantage, roll with normal advantage.

CRITICAL SUCCESSES AND FAILURES:

- Rolling a natural 20 on a d20 is a Critical Success: A Critical Success should produce an especially favorable result, whether narratively, mechanically, or both.
- Rolling a natural 1 on a d20 is a Critical Failure.: A Critical Failure should produce an especially unfavorable result, but does not automatically cause an extreme disaster.
- A Critical Success cannot make a truly impossible action possible.
- For details about how Critical Successes and Failures are applied in combat, see Chapter XX.

DIFFICULTY CLASSES:

- This is a number set by the GM during a check, to determine how difficult it is for the check to succeed.
- The lower the number, the simpler the task is to succeed at. The higher the number, the more difficult.
- Example: DC 10 for climbing a rough wall, DC 25 for climbing a sheer, ice-covered cliff.
- DCs generally should not exceed 30 (however, the GM may choose to ignore this if appropriate).
- If a task is absolutely impossible by any means, no check should be called for at all.

SAVING THROWS:

- Sometimes, a check must be made to avoid a dangerous obstacle, a trap, or certain kinds of attacks.
- These are called Saving Throws, and are simply a d20 roll plus one of your character's Attributes (STR/DEX/CON/INT/WIS/CHA).
- Rolling a natural 20 on a Saving Throw means you avoid all damage and effects.
- Rolling a natural 1 on a Saving Throw is automatically a failure, even if an added modifier would normally make it a success.

CONTESTED CHECKS:

- When two characters directly oppose each other, both make an appropriate Check. The character with the higher result succeeds.
- If the results are tied, both characters must roll again and use the new roll.
- Advantage, Disadvantage, and other modifiers apply normally.
- Contested checks are one of the most common ways to resolve Wildcard actions (see Chapter XX).

INSPIRATION:

- If a player is especially clever, the GM may reward them with a Point of Inspiration.
- Examples of this type of cleverness include: skilled role-playing, ingenious solutions to puzzles of problems, exceptionally hilarious moments, or brilliant observations or deductions.
- Mark this Point of Inspiration on your character sheet.
- You can have up to 5 Points of Inspiration at any given time.
- Points of Inspiration can be spent to re-roll a failed Check or Attack Roll.

CONDITIONS:

- Conditions are temporary states that alter how a character can act, move, or resolve certain rolls.
- A Condition remains in effect until its stated duration ends or its requirements for removal are met.
- By default, there are three Conditions: Exhausted, Prone, and Restrained.

[CONDITION] EXHAUSTED:

- Exhaustion may be inflicted by prolonged physical exertion, sleep deprivation, extreme environmental conditions, or other circumstances that leave a character physically exhausted.
- An Exhausted character has Disadvantage on checks involving strenuous physical activity.
- A Long Rest removes the Exhausted condition.

[CONDITION] PRONE:

- If a combatant is on the ground, willingly or unwillingly, it has the "Prone" condition.
- A prone combatant can stand back up either by using an action, or by sacrificing half of their total number of squares of movement for that turn (rounded up).
- A prone character can crawl along the ground at half the rate of their normal Movement.
- Melee attack rolls against a prone combatant may be granted Advantage.

[CONDITION] RESTRAINED:

- Certain moves, such as grappling an opponent, inflict the "Restrained" condition.
- A restrained creature's speed becomes 0, and it can't benefit from any bonus to its speed.
- Attack rolls against the creature have advantage, and the creature's attack rolls have disadvantage.
- The creature has disadvantage on Dexterity saving throws.

WEALTH:

- Your character's Wealth Level ranges from 1-10. (This takes the place of tracking individual currencies and coin counts.)
- The Game Master determines whether a purchase is reasonable for your Wealth Level.
- Unusually expensive purchases may reduce your Wealth Level.
- Wealth Level 1: Destitute. You struggle to afford basic necessities.
- Wealth Level 2: Poor. You can survive, but money is a constant concern.
- Wealth Level 3: Modest. You can afford ordinary necessities and minor comforts.
- Wealth Level 4: Comfortable. Routine expenses and common equipment are easily affordable.
- Wealth Level 5: Prosperous. You can afford quality goods, travel, and regular luxuries.
- Wealth Level 6: Wealthy. You have substantial resources, property, or income.
- Wealth Level 7: Very Wealthy. You can fund expeditions, employees, and major purchases.
- Wealth Level 8: Exceptionally Wealthy. You command resources comparable to nobles or major institutions.
- Wealth Level 9: Vast Fortune. You can finance armies, governments, or enormous projects.
- Wealth Level 10: Extreme Affluence. Only uniquely rare or world-changing purchases are beyond your reach.

EXPERIENCE:

- All player characters gain Levels at the same time.
- The GM awards a new Level when the group reaches an appropriate story milestone.
- For the mechanical effects and implications of gaining a Level, see Chapter XX.

Chapter 5: Character Identity

OSK'S CHARACTER-DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

- Much of OSK's mechanically streamlined design is intended specifically to allow creativity to flourish in other ways.
- Less mental exertion toward understanding rules means more capacity for embodying your character.
- Your character is more than their Species, Classes, Attributes, Skills, and Abilities.
- That being said, you do not need to write a long biography before play begins. A few clear ideas are usually enough to make them feel distinct and believable.

BACKSTORY AND GOALS:

- Consider where your character came from and which events shaped them.
- Think about why they became an adventurer and why they chose their Classes.
- Decide whether they have important allies, enemies, debts, promises, or unfinished business.
- Ask: "What does my character want right now?"
- Goals should encourage action rather than give the character a reason to avoid the adventure.

BELIEFS AND PERSONALITY:

- Consider what your character believes is right, wrong, sacred, dangerous, or necessary.
- Ask: "How would my character feel about authority, religion, magic, violence, wealth, or social status?"
- Think about how they speak, react, make decisions, and behave under pressure.
- Ask: "What makes my character angry, afraid, embarrassed, or excited?"
- Your character's beliefs may be conflicted and can change over time.

RELATIONSHIPS, STRENGTHS, AND FLAWS:

- Consider how your character treats strangers, allies, rivals, enemies, and authority figures.
- Ask: "Who does my character trust?"
- Ask: "What kind of person does my character dislike?"
- Give your character strengths beyond their mechanical abilities.
- Also give them flaws, fears, habits, or blind spots.
- Flaws should create interesting choices without constantly preventing the group from making progress.

DETAILS AND EMBODIMENT:

- Small details can make your character easier to portray.
- Consider their clothing, posture, gestures, hobbies, routines, tastes, and possessions.
- You can speak in character, or describe their words indirectly - or even use a mixture of both.
- You do not need to perform an accent or act dramatically.
- Ask: "What would my character notice, feel, say, or do in this situation?"

CHARACTER GROWTH:

- Your character does not need to remain the same throughout the campaign.
- Their goals, beliefs, relationships, and behavior may change during play.
- Failure, success, loss, friendship, and conflict can all shape them.
- Leave room for new discoveries and allow your character to surprise you.

ALIGNMENT:

- Feel free to think of your character's position on the standard 9-square alignment chart, with a "lawful vs chaotic" axis and a "good vs bad" axis.
- However, a character's alignment has almost no mechanical implications. It serves more of a guideline for roleplaying.

BASICS OF CHARACTER DESIGN:

- Characters are made up of a Species and two Classes.
- All of the character's characteristics, attributes, and abilities are represented on the Character Sheet and the Deck.

CHARACTER CREATION PROCEDURE:

- 1) Develop the concept of the character you want to portray and build (see Chapter XX).
- 2) Select a Species for your character, and design a Species Card with 1-3 traits.
- 3) Select two Classes for your character.
- 4) Fill in your Character Sheet: Character Name, Attribute Points, Skill Points, Hit Points, Movement, Wealth, Combat Modifier, Combat Save DC, etc (refer to the chart at the end of this chapter).
- 5) Design 5 Ability Cards that fit your character's Classes (see Chapter XX).

SPECIES:

- Your Species represents your character's biological or supernatural lineage, also sometimes referred to as "race" or "heritage". Examples include humans, elves, dwarves, gnomes, orcs, etc.
- OSK does not use a fixed Species list. Instead, you can adapt Species from other comparable TTRPGs (provided that those species fit with the setting your group is playing in).
- This book provides example Species Cards for common fantasy Species (see Chapter XX). You can use one as written, modify it, or use it as a model for your own.
- Choose a Species that fits both your character concept and the campaign setting.
- A Species Card should usually contain 1–3 traits that represent the Species' most defining innate characteristics. Design these traits using the same general principles as Ability design (see Chapter XX).
- Traits that provide minor benefits (such as the ability to see well in the dark) should be one trait of several.
- Traits that provide major benefits (such as the ability to fly) should generally be the only trait on that Species card (unless the GM and group decide otherwise).
- Species traits should represent inherent qualities. Training, professions, and learned techniques are usually better represented by Skills, Classes, or Abilities.

CLASSES:

- Classes define your character's archetype. Most OSK characters are made up of a Primary Class and a Secondary Class, and they gain experience in both Classes simultaneously.
- Your Classes primarily determine which Source Abilities you can use when designing your own Abilities.
- When choosing Classes, think about what you want your character to do: fighting style, magic, special techniques, signature abilities, etc.
- OSK does not use "subclasses"; however, when creating Abilities, you are still free to choose Source Abilities from any subclass belonging to either of your Classes.
- If you strongly desire it, you can create a "monoclass" character with only one Class. This provides no benefit other than simplicity.

LANGUAGES:

- All characters can speak Common (the "lingua franca" of most settings), plus the language associated with their species (if different from Common).
- Beyond that, a character's fluency in other languages is determined by their Language skill.

CHARACTER ATTRIBUTES:

- Your character's physical and mental attributes are represented by their Attributes.
- Attributes can range from a minimum of +0 to a maximum of +5.
- OSK uses the same classic six Attributes as countless other TTRPGs:
- Strength (STR) - a character's physical might and power
- Dexterity (DEX) - a character's agility, in terms of speed, nimbleness, and hand-eye coordination
- Constitution (CON) - a character's physical endurance, their heartiness and ability to withstand pain and exert themselves
- Intelligence (INT) - a character's raw reasoning ability, their mental horsepower, and their skills at deduction and logic
- Wisdom (WIS) - a character's instincts, intuition, and ability to anticipate the results of future actions.
- Charisma (CHA) - a character's presence, their ability to persuade, flirt, or deceive.

CHARACTER SKILLS:

- Skills represent your character's proficiency in broad categories of tasks.
- Skill modifiers range from +3 to +15, based on the skill points you allocate toward them as you level up.
- You cannot have a modifier higher than +6 before Level 4, and you cannot have one higher than +12 until Level 8.
- For more information on Skills, see Chapter XX.

ABILITIES:

- Each ability is represented by a 3x5 card.
- Characters start with 5 Designed Abilities based on the two Classes they've selected.
- These abilities can be fighting maneuvers, magic spells, or other features that help them in or out of combat.
- Players design these abilities based on the guidelines outlined in Chapter XX.
- Every time a character levels up, you create up to 2 more Ability cards. A Level 10 character will have 23 total Abilities.

COMBAT MODIFIER / COMBAT SAVE DC:

- These are modifiers that are used with Abilities during combat. They jointly represent your character's overall combat proficiency.
- Your Combat Modifier is any Attribute of your choice, plus your current Level.
- You can choose which Attribute is the basis of your Combat Modifier during a Long Rest.
- All abilities that involve Attack Rolls are resolved with this single Combat Modifier.
- Your Combat Save DC is your Combat Modifier plus 7.

INVENTORY / STARTING GEAR:

- Characters are not limited in what gear they can start with, so long as their choices are within reason.
- A starting kit of mundane equipment can all be combined onto a single Equipment card.
- OSK generally assumes that most martial (i.e. non-magic-using) characters start with both a hand-to-hand weapon and a ranged weapon of some kind - but this is ultimately up to the player.
- OSK is not concerned with a character's inventory capacity, and by default there is no limit on the number of cards in a character's deck.
- Inventory capacity can be narratively hand-waived in any number of ways. For example, assuming that each character starts with a Bag of Holding (a magical bag with an infinite carrying capacity).
- A character's armor is already considered part of their team's shared AC (See Chapter XX). In other words: unless it is armor with special properties, your choice of armor is largely cosmetic.
- A party's wealth should begin at the level that makes the most narrative sense.

LEVELING UP:

- Your character's Experience Level ranges from 1-10. This is tracked on your character sheet.
- You gain levels in both of your character's classes simultaneously.
- Your whole adventuring party levels up simultaneously.
- At every Level after 1st, you may create 2 new Ability cards.
- If the players and GM all agree, these cards may be created one at a time: one when you gain the Level, and the second later at an appropriate point. This can reduce the burden of designing and balancing multiple new Abilities at once.
- Additionally, at every level after 1st, you gain Attribute Points, Skill Points, and Hit Points based on a chart (see below).
- The GM determines the most appropriate time for a party to level up (typically based on story milestones).

ATTRIBUTE / SKILL BUBBLES:

- Your character sheet has bubbles that are used to show their current level of allocated points for each Attribute and Skill.
- Bubbles are filled in from left to right; each new Attribute Point or Skill Point can be spent to fill in a bubble, which increases that Attribute/Skill's Modifier.

LEVEL-UP CHART:

- This chart shows how your character's stats and characteristics change as they level up:

Character Level	Combat Modifier	Combat Save DC	Total Attribute Pts	Total Skill Pts	Hit Points	Armor Class
1	+6	13	11	14	26	14
2	+7	14	12	16	42	15
3	+8	15	13	18	58	16
4	+9	16	14	20	74	17
5	+10	17	15	22	90	18
6	+11	18	16	24	106	19
7	+12	19	17	26	122	20
8	+13	20	18	28	138	21
9	+14	21	19	30	154	22
10	+15	22	20	32	170	23

SKILLS IN OSK

- Skills in OSK are largely identical to D&D 5E, with a few adjustments.
- Note that Skills in OSK ARE NOT coupled to Attributes.
- The GM determines which Skill is appropriate for a given check.
- Additionally, if a Skill is roleplayed in a particularly clever way, the GM may grant advantage on the check. (Note that Persuasion is a special case in this regard - see below.)
- If a task does not easily fit into one of the given Skill categories, the GM may call for a check with an Attribute modifier instead.
- Skills in OSK are intentionally broad, and may achieve more than their standard 5E equivalents.
- For example, an Arcana check might identify a magical effect, or reveal whether an object is enchanted.

ACROBATICS:

- Acrobatics represents balance, flexibility, coordination, and controlled movement.
- Use it to balance on a narrow surface, perform a difficult landing, tumble through an obstacle, or escape certain restraints.

ANIMAL HANDLING:

- Animal Handling represents your ability to understand, calm, train, ride, or direct animals.
- Use it to soothe a frightened mount, interpret an animal's behavior, or persuade a wild creature not to attack.

ARCANA:

- Arcana represents knowledge and practical understanding of magic, enchantments, supernatural forces, and magical creatures.
- Use it to identify a spell, examine an enchanted object, interpret magical symbols, or detect nearby magical influence.

ATHLETICS:

- Athletics represents physical training, strength, endurance, and forceful movement.
- Use it to climb, swim, jump, grapple, shove, break an object, or perform another feat of physical power.

DECEPTION:

- Deception represents your ability to conceal the truth, mislead others, impersonate someone, or maintain a false story.
- Use it to lie convincingly, disguise your intentions, create a distraction, or pass yourself off as someone else.
- At the GM's discretion, Deception Checks can follow the same special rules as Persuasion Checks (see below).

HISTORY:

- History represents knowledge of past events, cultures, nations, wars, rulers, and important figures.
- Use it to recall historical information, recognize an ancient symbol, or understand the significance of a location or artifact.

INSIGHT:

- Insight represents your ability to interpret emotions, intentions, behavior, and social cues.
- Use it to recognize deception, determine someone's mood, anticipate their likely response, or understand an unspoken motive.

INTIMIDATION:

- Intimidation represents your ability to influence others through fear, threats, force, or overwhelming presence.
- Use it to frighten an opponent, compel cooperation, or discourage someone from taking action.

INVESTIGATION:

- Investigation represents careful examination, deduction, research, and the discovery of concealed information.
- Use it to search an area, find hidden objects, reconstruct events, analyze clues, or uncover the workings of a trap.

MEDICINE:

- Medicine represents knowledge of injury, illness, anatomy, treatment, and first aid.
- Use it to restore HP through the First Aid action.
- Use it to diagnose a condition, stabilize an injured creature, or identify a poison or disease.

NATURE:

- Nature represents knowledge of plants, animals, weather, ecosystems, and natural phenomena.
- Use it to identify a creature or plant, predict weather, understand an environment, or recognize a natural hazard.

PERFORMANCE:

- Performance represents your ability to entertain, captivate, or emotionally affect an audience.
- Use it to sing, dance, act, play an instrument, tell a story, or deliver a dramatic speech.

RELIGION:

- Religion represents knowledge of gods, faiths, rituals, sacred traditions, divine forces, and supernatural beliefs.
- Use it to identify religious symbols, recall doctrine, pray for divine aid, perform a ritual, or understand the behavior of a divine or unholy creature.

SLEIGHT OF HAND:

- Sleight of Hand represents precise manual coordination, concealment, and subtle manipulation.
- Use it to pick a lock, pickpocket a passerby, hide a small object, perform a hand trick, palm an item, or manipulate a delicate mechanism unnoticed.

STEALTH:

- Stealth represents your ability to avoid detection through silence, concealment, timing, or camouflage.
- Use it to move quietly, hide, follow someone unseen, or conceal signs of your presence.

SURVIVAL:

- Survival represents practical experience with wilderness travel, tracking, navigation, shelter, and environmental danger.
- Use it to follow tracks, avoid becoming lost, locate food or water, anticipate an ambush, or endure dangerous terrain.

ENGINEERING:

- Engineering represents knowledge of machines, structures, construction, traps, and mechanical systems.
- Use it to repair machinery, assess a bridge's stability, disable a mechanical trap, or build a contraption.

LANGUAGE:

- Language represents knowledge of spoken, written, signed, coded, and ancient forms of communication.
- By default, characters understand Common (i.e. the language understood almost universally) and any language associated with their Species.
- Use Language to translate unfamiliar writing, understand a related language, interpret a code, or communicate across a language barrier.
- A character with a +12 or +15 Language modifier is effectively a polyglot.

[SPECIAL SKILL] PERSUASION:

- Persuasion represents your minimum competence in reasoned or charismatic social influence.
- Use it to persuade, impress, negotiate, haggle, flirt, or request cooperation.
- Your Persuasion modifier is the minimum modifier added to a Persuasion Check.
- However, if a player engages in impressive, clever, or dramatic roleplaying, the GM may grant a higher modifier (from +3 to +15).
- Additionally, note that a successful Persuasion Check cannot still force another character to act irrationally or against deeply held convictions.

THE GRID:

- OSK unambiguously assumes combat takes place on a gridded map.
- Each square on the normally represents 5 feet.

COMBATANTS AND TEAMS:

- Combatants are divided into a Player Team and an Enemy Team.
- The Player Team normally consists of the player characters and their allies.
- The Enemy Team consists of hostile creatures controlled by the GM.
- Some encounters may involve neutral creatures or additional teams at the GM's discretion.

BEGINNING COMBAT:

- Combat begins when the GM determines that actions must be resolved turn by turn.
- Position all relevant combatants on the grid.
- Both teams then roll Initiative (taking Surprise into account, if applicable).

INITIATIVE:

- One member of the Player Team rolls a d20 with no modifier.
- The GM rolls a d20 with no modifier for the Enemy Team.
- The team with the higher result takes the first turn. If the results are tied, both teams reroll.
- Initiative is rolled only once at the beginning of combat.
- After Initiative is determined, play alternates between the two teams.
- On each team's turn, that team chooses one combatant who has not yet acted during the current round.
- That combatant immediately takes their turn.
- Each combatant may take only one turn per round.
- If one team has more combatants than the other, the larger team may take consecutive turns after every member of the smaller team has acted.
- Once every combatant has taken a turn, the round ends and a new round begins.
- The team that won Initiative takes the first turn of each new round.

SURPRISE:

- If one team catches the other off guard, the surprised team rolls Initiative with Disadvantage.
- The GM determines whether Surprise applies based on the circumstances.

ENDING COMBAT:

- Combat ends when no hostile combatants remain willing or able to fight.
- Cards in the Cooldown Queue are returned to the Loadout.

LOADOUT IN COMBAT:

- During your turn combat, you can normally use only cards in your Loadout.
- Your Loadout can contain up to 10 cards.
- Your Species card is always available and does not count against this limit.
- Cards in your Deck are carried by your character but are not immediately available.
- Use the Reconfigure Action to exchange cards between your Loadout and Deck (see below).

THREE ACTIONS PER TURN:

- On your turn in combat, you can take up to three Actions.
- There are seven types of Actions: Use Ability, Use Equipment, Use Consumable, Movement, Reconfigure, First Aid, and Wildcard.
- You can take actions in any order.
- You cannot take any one action type more than twice on a single turn.
- You can only add one card to the Cooldown Queue per turn, unless you play a Combo card.
- A card with the Combo trait lets you play it into Cooldown Slot 1 on the same turn as another card.
- You may choose to take fewer than three Actions; however, unused Actions are lost at the end of your turn unless you Hold one of them.

[ACTION TYPE] USE ABILITY:

- Use this Action to activate an Ability card in your Loadout.
- An Ability may involve an Attack Roll, Saving Throw, damage, movement, healing, or another effect.
- Most Abilities enter the Cooldown Queue after use.
- Only one card may enter the Cooldown Queue during your turn (unless a Combo card is used).

[ACTION TYPE] USE EQUIPMENT:

- Use this Action to activate an Equipment card in your Loadout.
- Some Equipment enters the Cooldown Queue after use.
- Passive Equipment functions automatically while it remains in your Loadout; it does not require an Action.
- For more information on Equipment, see Chapter XX.

[ACTION TYPE] USE CONSUMABLE:

- Use this Action to activate a Consumable card in your Loadout.
- Consumables include potions, scrolls, special ammunition, special foods, and similar single-use items.
- After a Consumable is used, remove it from your Deck.
- Consumables do not normally enter the Cooldown Queue unless the card states otherwise.

[ACTION TYPE] MOVEMENT:

- Use this Action to move up to your Movement value in squares. Movement may be orthogonal, diagonal, or a combination of both.
- Most characters have a default Movement value of 6 (i.e. 30ft).
- You may split your movement before and after other Actions taken during the same turn.
- If you take the Movement Action twice, each Action grants up to your full Movement value.

- You may move through a willing ally's square, but cannot end your movement there. You cannot normally move through an enemy's square.
- Swimming and climbing are (by default) at half speed (i.e. 3 squares per Movement action).
- A Species trait, Ability, or Equipment card may allow you to swim or climb at full speed.
- The Game Master may call for a Check when swimming or climbing is especially difficult.
- Flying: A character cannot normally fly without an appropriate Species trait, Ability, or Equipment.

[ACTION TYPE] RECONFIGURE:

- Use this Action to exchange any number of cards between your Loadout and Deck - AFTER your current turn ends.
- The new Loadout becomes active at the start of your following turn.
- Cards currently in the Cooldown Queue cannot be moved into your Deck.
- Your Loadout cannot exceed 10 cards after Reconfiguration.

[ACTION TYPE] FIRST AID:

- This action allows you to restore HP to yourself or to an adjacent combatant.
- Make a Medicine check, and add the amount rolled to target's current HP. The target then spends one Recovery Point.
- A character without Recovery Points cannot regain HP through First Aid.
- A dying character can be stabilized even if they do not have any available Recovery Points (see Chapter XX).

[ACTION TYPE] WILDCARD:

- Use this Action to attempt to do almost anything that makes sense in the current situation, within reason.
- Describe what your character is trying to accomplish.
- The GM determines whether the attempt is possible and how it is resolved.
- Wildcards actions are commonly resolved using standard Checks, contested Checks, and/or improvised damage. Resolution is at the GM's discretion.
- Wildcards encourage creative interaction with enemies, objects, terrain, and the environment.

WILDCARD LIMITATIONS

- You cannot use your Wildcard to duplicate any other Action type.
- You cannot use your Wildcard to simply cause more damage (it is not an "extra attack").
- Wildcards can involve whatever weapons you are currently wielding.
- Wildcards generally involve little-to-no magic or supernatural abilities.
- Particularly creative or dramatic Wildcards may be granted Advantage by the GM.
- Conversely, Wildcards used in abusive or repetitive ways may incur Disadvantage.
- The GM has final authority over Wildcard outcomes.

EXAMPLE WILDCARD ACTIONS:

- Hide, or duck behind nearby cover.
- Trip, shove, grapple, or disarm an enemy.
- Distract, insult, frighten, or deceive an opponent.
- Throw sand into an enemy's eyes.
- Overturn a table to create cover.
- Use a nearby object as an improvised weapon.
- Shoot down a hanging chandelier.
- Rally an ally with words of encouragement.
- Start, spread, or extinguish a fire.

HOLD & TRIGGER:

- You can choose to Hold one action on your turn, to wait for a specified Trigger before activating.
- You specify the held action's Trigger when you choose to hold it.
- If the Trigger occurs before the beginning of your next turn, you may immediately take the held Action.
- The held action can be an action of any type.
- You may choose not to activate the held Action when the Trigger occurs.
- If the Trigger does not occur before your next turn begins, the held Action is lost.
- A held Action cannot be changed after your turn ends.

BETWEEN-TURN EFFECTS:

- OSK does not use predefined between-turn effects (often known as "Reactions").
- Characters generally do not interrupt another combatant's turn unless they have Held an action.
- However, Abilities and Equipment may create specific effects that occur between turns.

THE COOLDOWN QUEUE:

- The Cooldown Queue represents the time or effort required before certain Abilities or Equipment can be used again.
- The Queue contains two Cooldown Slots. Cards enter the Queue through Cooldown Slot 1.
- When a new card enters Slot 1, any cards already in the Queue advance to the next Slot.
- A card moved beyond Cooldown Slot 2 returns to your Loadout.
- Any cards in the Cooldown Queue cannot be moved into your Deck by the Reconfigure action.
- Certain cards may have effects that remain activated so long as the card is in the Queue. When the card leaves the Queue, any sustained effect ends unless the card states otherwise.

COMBO CARDS:

- Normally, only one card may enter the Cooldown Queue during your turn.
- This limit applies across Ability and Equipment cards.
- However, a Combo card is an Ability or Equipment card designed to be used alongside another card.
- A Combo card may enter Cooldown Slot 1 during the same turn as one other card.
- Place the Combo card above or below the other card in Slot 1.
- The card on top advances through and leaves the Queue before the card beneath it.
- The player chooses the order unless one of the cards specifies otherwise.
- A Combo card still requires its normal Action unless the card states otherwise.
- Only one Combo card may bypass the normal Cooldown limit during a turn.

HIGH-LEVEL ABILITIES:

- Abilities acquired at levels 9 and 10 are special abilities that do not require cooldown.
- Rather, these abilities are "once per day" abilities that regain usability after a Long Rest.
- This is because these abilities are exceptionally powerful, and generally require more exertion from the character to employ.

ARMOR CLASS:

- Each team has one shared Armor Class. This represents armor, agility, defensive skill, luck, and the general difficulty of inflicting a decisive blow.
- The Player Team's Armor Class is equal to the party's current Level plus 13 (i.e. ranging from 14-23).
- The GM assigns the Enemy Team an Armor Class appropriate to the encounter. Enemy Armor Class generally ranges from 10 to 25.

ATTACK ROLLS:

- When an Ability calls for an Attack Roll, roll a d20 and add your Combat Modifier. Compare the result to the opposing team's Armor Class.
- The Ability card describes its "Over-AC" and "Under-AC" results.

OVER-AC / UNDER-AC:

- If an Attack Roll meets or exceeds the target team's Armor Class, use the Ability's Over-AC result.
- If the Attack Roll is lower than the target team's Armor Class, use the Ability's Under-AC result.
- An Under-AC result does not typically represent a complete miss. It may represent a glancing blow, partial success, reduced damage, or a resisted effect.
- However, a Critical Miss overrides the normal Under-AC result.

OFFENSIVING SAVING THROWS:

- Instead of Attack Rolls, some abilities call for enemy targets to make Saving Throws. Compare the result(s) to the attacker's Combat Save DC.
- The target rolls a d20 and adds the specified Attribute.
- The Ability card describes its "Enemy Fails Throw" and "Enemy Succeeds Throw" results.
- For the general rules for Saving Throws and Critical Successes or Failures, see Chapter XX.

CRITICAL HITS:

- Rolling a Natural 20 on an Attack Roll is a Critical Hit. On a Critical Hit, calculate the total damage inflicted by the attack as you normally would - then double that result.
- Secondary effects are not typically doubled.

CRITICAL MISSES:

- Rolling a natural 1 on an Attack Roll is a Critical Miss. On a Critical Miss, the Ability or Equipment has no effect.
- The card still enters the Cooldown Queue if it normally requires Cooldown.
- A Critical Miss does not end the rest of your turn.

LINE OF SIGHT / COVER:

- You must normally be able to see a target to directly target it.
- Solid walls and similar barriers block Line of Sight.
- Smoke, darkness, concealment, and other conditions may impose Disadvantage or prevent targeting.
- A combatant has Cover when a substantial object blocks part of their body.
- Partial Cover normally imposes Disadvantage on Attack Rolls against that combatant.
- Total Cover prevents direct targeting.
- The Game Master determines whether Line of Sight is clear, or if Cover applies based on the combatants' positions.

ATTACKS OF OPPORTUNITY:

- OSK does not use Attacks of Opportunity (this is a term for striking an opponent that moves away from you without disengaging first).
- Moving away from an enemy does not normally trigger an attack, and there is no "Disengage" Action.
- Specific Abilities may restrict movement or punish enemies who move away.

FLANKING:

- A combatant is Flanked when two enemies occupy directly opposite adjacent squares around them. The two attackers may be positioned orthogonally or diagonally.
- Melee Attack Rolls against a Flanked combatant have Advantage.

IMPROVISED DAMAGE:

- Certain situations may require the GM to improvise damage amounts.
- This improvisational damage generally ranges from 1d6 to 10d6, but the GM may allow for even more d6 if the situation calls for it.

TERRAIN:

- Battlemaps may contain certain areas of "Difficult Terrain", such as sheets of ice, patches of sharp brambles, or quicksand.
- This type of terrain costs twice as much movement to pass through.
- For example, if a character normally has a Movement value of 6 squares per turn, they may only be able to move 3 squares per turn through Difficult Terrain.

DYING:

- When a player's character reaches 0 HP, they fall unconscious and are considered dying.
- An unconscious character cannot take Actions, and must make a Death Saving Throw at the end of EACH player's turn.
- For information on Death and Death Saving Throws, see Chapter XX.

THE TEN COMMANDMENTS OF ABILITY DESIGN:

- Thou Shalt Not Deliberately Design Disruptive, Problematic, Or Unbalanced Abilities.
- Thou Shalt Base Thy Designed Abilities On Source Abilities From Thy Chosen Classes.
- Thou Shalt Preserve The Source Ability's Fantasy, Function, Or Both.
- Thou Shalt Make All Abilities Fit On A 3x5 Card.
- Thou Shalt Define Thy Ability Mechanics And Characteristics Clearly.
- Thou Shalt Temper Power With Limitations.
- Thou Shalt Ensure Quick And Simple Resolution.
- Thou Shalt Respect The Cooldown Queue And Loadout.
- Thou Shalt Avoid Permanent Answers To Broad Categories Of Problems.
- Thou Shalt Respect Thy GM's Judgment On Ability Balance.

THE BASICS OF ABILITY DESIGN:

- Ability design is a conversation, not a strict mathematical formula.
- OSK does not expect players to build abilities entirely from scratch. Instead, begin with a Source Ability: a spell, feature, maneuver, trait, or similar ability associated with one of your character's Classes.
- The goal is not to perfectly reproduce the Source Ability. The goal is to preserve its vibe and/or function, while customizing it and making it fast, clear, and fun to use in OSK.
- A Designed Ability may adjust the Source Ability's damage, range, or other traits and mechanics. However, major strengths should generally remain paired with comparable limitations.
- In OSK, complex characters should be created by cleverly crafting and combining simple cards - not by writing complex cards!

3X5 NOTECARDS:

- EVERY Designed Ability must be represented by a 3x5 notecard (or an equivalent thereof, such as a 3"x5" slip of paper, or a digital image of approximately the same information density).
- If an ability's text cannot comfortably fit on one card, it is probably too complicated. (And don't shrink the text into unreadability to try to cheat this rule!)
- Whenever possible, remove exceptions and unnecessary wording rather than adding more text.

CARD LAYOUT:

- Your Ability card should contain the following information:
- The Ability's name
- The Level at which the Ability was designed and gained (or substationally modified - see RETROACTIVE ABILITY CARD CHANGES)
- The Source Ability, including its original Class or source
- Flavor text (a short description of what the Ability looks, sounds, or feels like - be sure to make it badass!)
- The Ability's mechanics and resolution
- Mechanics should include only information necessary to use the Ability during play.
- Pro-Tip: A "portrait" orientation (with the notecard so the short edges are at the top and bottom) is often more space-efficient than "landscape" orientation.

A WARNING TO POWERGAMERS AND OPTIMIZERS:

- OSK gives players unusually broad control over their own mechanical abilities. That freedom depends on players designing in good faith.
- Do not deliberately exploit gaps, ambiguities, unintended combinations, or generous interpretations to create an obviously overpowered Ability.
- Optimization itself is not a problem. The problem is creating an Ability whose purpose is to bypass the game's intended tradeoffs.
- If an Ability proves too powerful, too vague, too disruptive, or too complicated, it must be revised.
- The GM is the final arbiter of whether a Designed Ability is appropriate for the game.

THE ABILITY DESIGN PROCEDURE:

- Ability design should generally follow these six steps:
- STEP 1) Choose a Source Ability.
- STEP 2) Keep the Concept Simple.
- STEP 3) Consider the Tradeoffs and Limitations.
- STEP 4) Write the Card.
- STEP 5) Assess the Designed Ability.
- STEP 6) Revise After Playtesting.

STEP 1) CHOOSE A SOURCE ABILITY:

- Start by choosing a feature, spell, maneuver, or similar ability associated with one of your Classes.
- The Source Ability should normally be available to a character at approximately the same point in progression as your OSK character. Exact Level equivalence is not required, especially when converting from a system with different advancement.
- Instead, consider how powerful, important, or defining the Source Ability is within its original game. Ask what originally attracted you to it.
- Consider its fantasy: What makes it cool, distinctive, or thematic?
- Consider its function: What does it actually accomplish mechanically?
- Decide which of those elements your Designed Ability should preserve. A Designed Ability should always have a clear purpose.

STEP 2) KEEP THE CONCEPT SIMPLE:

- Remove details from the Source Ability that are unnecessary in OSK.
- Remove or rewrite mechanics that would require excessive calculation, repeated dice rolls, long reference text, or complicated exceptions.
- Replace unfamiliar mechanics with existing OSK systems whenever practical.
- DO NOT remove restrictions merely because they are inconvenient. Many restrictions exist specifically to prevent an Ability from becoming too broad or powerful.
- Keep the part of the Source Ability that made you want it in the first place.
- In general, the simpler an Ability is to understand during combat, the better.

STEP 3) CONSIDER THE TRADEOFFS/LIMITATIONS:

- Ask what prevents the Source Ability from being useful in every situation. What aspects of the Source Ability make it balanced and fair?
- An Ability that is stronger in one dimension should usually be weaker in another.
- For example: a single-target, close-range Ability with no secondary effects may deal very high damage. Conversely, an Ability that attacks several creatures, functions from long range, applies a strong debuff, or offers significant utility should generally deal less damage.
- An ability's limitations are the counterbalance that keep it from being the solutions to all problems - which would make for a narratively and tactically boring game!
- Example limitations include:
 - Shorter Range
 - Fewer Targets
 - Lower Damage
 - A weaker Under-AC or successful-Save result
 - Limited Duration
 - Positioning requirements
 - Personal risk
 - Self-damage
 - Requiring another Ability, object, circumstance, or setup
- The limitation should be a meaningful counterpoint to the Ability's strongest advantages.
- The stronger, broader, more reliable, or longer-lasting an effect is, the more substantial its limitations should usually be.

STEP 4) WRITE THE CARD:

- Write the Ability so that another player could understand it without requiring an explanation from its creator. Clearly state the mechanics that actually matter during play.
- Remember that your Ability's text MUST fit on a 3x5 notecard!
- Ensure your Designed Ability contains the following information (where applicable):
 - Range: How far away may the target be?
 - Target(s): Who or what can be affected?
 - Area of Effect: Which squares are affected?
 - Cooldown: Does the card require Cooldown?
 - Resolution: Does the Ability use an Attack Roll, Saving Throw, Check, contested Check, or no roll?
 - Results: What happens on an Over-AC and Under-AC result, or when a target succeeds or fails a Saving Throw?
 - Damage Output: Which Damage Tier applies?
 - Damage Type: What type of damage is inflicted?
 - Duration: How long does the effect last?
 - Buff/Debuff: Does the Ability help allies or hinder enemies beyond dealing damage?
 - Conditions: Does the Ability inflict or remove a defined condition?
 - Limitations: Are there any important requirements, risks, or restrictions?

STEP 5) ASSESS THE DESIGNED ABILITY:

- Ask yourself these questions about your Designed Ability:
 - Is its purpose clear?
 - Is it quick to resolve?
 - Does it preserve the fantasy, function, or both of its Source Ability?
 - Are its strongest benefits tempered by meaningful limitations?
 - Would another player understand the card without explanation?
 - Does it create an interesting choice rather than an obvious answer?
 - Does it overlap too strongly with another Ability the character already has?
 - Does it fall into a category of Ability Types to Avoid, as described in Chapter XX?
 - Would it feel reasonably fair if an enemy used a comparable Ability against the party?
- If the answer to any of these questions is no, revise the Ability.

STEP 6) REVISE AFTER TESTING:

- No amount of theory can perfectly predict how every Ability will behave during actual play. A Designed Ability may need to be "dialed in", and modified slightly after it is tested in play.
- Revise an Ability if it proves too strong, too weak, too vague, too complicated, too slow, or too disruptive.
- Small numerical adjustments are often preferable to completely redesigning a card.
- Examples include changing Damage Tier, Range, Area, Duration, Cooldown, or the strength of an Under-AC result.
- However, a major mechanical problem may require a more substantial redesign.
- Players should not treat post-play revision as a punishment. The goal is for everyone - including the GM - to have fun.
- Remember: Ability design is an ongoing conversation between the player, the GM, and the group.

ABILITY PARAMETERS:

- Every Designed Ability is made up of several mechanical parameters that determine what it can do, how reliably it works, and how powerful it is.
- Think of an Ability's parameters as adjustable "dials" that can be tuned until an ability is balanced.
- Example parameters include damage dealt, range, number of targets, area of effect, etc.
- For more on ability parameters and balance, see Chapter XX.

THE COOLDOWN QUEUE:

- Most powerful or repeatable combat Abilities should require Cooldown (in other words, they should interact with the Cooldown Queue).
- As a general rule, if the Source Ability consumes an important limited resource in its original system, its OSK equivalent should strongly be considered for Cooldown.
- Cooldown is not merely a penalty. It creates rotation between different cards and prevents one strong Ability from being repeated every turn.
- An Ability that does not require Cooldown should generally be weaker, narrower, passive, situational, or otherwise limited.
- For more on the Cooldown Queue, see Chapter XX.

COOLDOWN QUEUE FOR SUSTAINED ABILITIES:

- Some TTRPG abilities remain active while their user maintains "concentration" or a similar ongoing commitment.
- OSK does not use Concentration as a universal mechanic. A simple alternative is to keep the Ability's effect active while its card remains in the Cooldown Queue.
- When the card leaves the Queue, the effect ends unless the card states otherwise.
- Particularly powerful sustained effects may require additional limitations.
- Avoid sustained Abilities that require constant recalculation or repeated bookkeeping.

DESIGNING COMBO CARDS:

- Abilities with the "Combo" trait are cards that require Cooldown, but which CAN be played on the same turn as another Ability that requires Cooldown.
- Combo cards can be played either before or after the paired card. Both cards go into Cooldown Slot 1 on the same turn, and both cards move through the Queue simultaneously.
- Combo cards are intended to support another action rather than compete with full-strength Abilities.
- If a Source Ability was designed to supplement another action on the same turn, it may be appropriate as a Combo card.
- D&D 5E Bonus Actions are common candidates, but being a Bonus Action does not automatically make something an appropriate Combo.
- Combo cards should generally provide secondary damage, mobility, setup, defense, utility, or another supporting effect.
- A Combo card should not normally be comparable in raw power to a full Ability that occupies the turn's normal Cooldown allowance.
- Only one Combo card may bypass the normal Cooldown limit during a turn.

RESOLUTION MECHANICS:

- Whenever practical, preserve the Source Ability's basic method of resolution.
- If the Source Ability uses an Attack Roll, its OSK equivalent should usually use an Attack Roll. If the Source Ability requires a Saving Throw, its OSK equivalent should usually require a Saving Throw.
- This is a guideline rather than an absolute rule. Changing the resolution method is acceptable when doing so makes the Ability clearer or better suited to OSK.
- Attack Roll Abilities should generally require no more than a single Attack Roll, even if the Ability targets multiple opponents. Avoid trying to "split up" one Ability into multiple "mini-Abilities" with multiple Attack Rolls.
- Attack Roll Abilities normally have both an Over-AC and Under-AC result.
- The Over-AC result should be meaningfully stronger. The Under-AC result should usually still accomplish something unless the Ability is specifically designed around greater risk.
- Saving Throw Abilities should likewise define what happens when the target succeeds and when it fails.

UNDER-AC AND ENEMY-SAVES RESULTS:

- Partial results are an important part of OSK's combat design.
- An Under-AC result may deal lower-tier damage, remove a secondary effect, shorten a duration, reduce an area, or otherwise produce a weaker version of the Ability.
- A successful enemy Saving Throw may use similar principles.
- The weaker result should still be worth resolving quickly. Do not create excessively complicated branching outcomes.
- Some high-risk Abilities may intentionally have an extremely weak Under-AC result. This may justify unusually powerful Over-AC effects.

RETROACTIVE ABILITY CARD CHANGES:

- Some Source Abilities improve an existing feature rather than granting an entirely new one.
- Instead of designing a new card when leveling up, you can choose to make a "major revision" to an existing card, in line with that corresponding Source Ability.
- Be sure to record on the card the level(s) at which the card was substantially revised. For example: "[L1] Eldritch Blast" may later become: "[L1/L5] Eldritch Blast"

LIMITS ON RETROACTIVE CHANGES:

- Designed Abilities are not meant to be constantly tweaked, rewritten, or swapped out merely for situational optimization. Once an Ability is balanced and working as intended, it should generally remain part of your character without further modification.
- However, if a player genuinely dislikes an Ability they've created, the group (and GM) should generally be flexible and understanding in allowing the player to design a replacement Ability.

OVERLAPPING ABILITIES:

- Two Abilities may perform similar functions, but each should ideally create a meaningfully different choice.
- Avoid designing several cards where one is simply a stronger version of another in almost every circumstance.
- Different versions of the same concept can instead vary through range, targets, damage, risk, area, conditions, setup, or utility.
- Upgrading an existing card may sometimes be cleaner than adding another nearly identical card.

COMBINING SOURCE ABILITIES:

- A Designed Ability may be based on more than one Source Ability. This is most appropriate when the Source Abilities are individually minor, simple, or closely related.
- The combined Ability should still have clear and simple to understand, and it should still resolve quickly.
- Combining Source Abilities does not justify combining their full power without adjustment.
- If the resulting Ability is stronger, broader, or more flexible than either Source Ability alone, reduce its Damage, Range, Duration, reliability, or other benefits as necessary.
- Do not combine several strong Source Abilities into a single card simply to gain multiple major effects at once.
- As always, the final Designed Ability should remain balanced, quick to resolve, and appropriate for its Level.

DESIGNING HIGH-LEVEL ABILITIES:

- Abilities gained at Levels 9 and 10 called Nova Abilities.
- Nova Abilities may deliberately break some of the assumptions that govern ordinary cards. They should feel dramatic, character-defining, and substantially more powerful than normal Abilities.
- By default, Nova Abilities are usable once per Long Rest.
- More detailed guidance for Nova Ability design appears in chapter XX.

REFLAVORING ABILITIES:

- The simplest way to create a Designed Ability is to simply re flavor an existing example Ability card, keeping its mechanics mostly or entirely unchanged while altering its theme.
- For example, you might turn "Fireball" into "Iceball" by changing its description and damage type from Fire to Cold.
- This is a fast, reliable way to create a custom Ability without needing to rebalance it from scratch.

SYSTEM MODULARITY (A.K.A. WHEN TO THROW ABILITY GUIDELINES OUT THE WINDOW):

- OSK is intentionally modular. Your group may collectively choose to alter any of these guidelines to better suit your preferred style.
- Example: You can use 5x7 cards instead of 3x5 cards, and/or use digital cards instead of physical.
- Example: You can throw out Source Abilities and create all Designed Abilities completely from scratch.
- Example: You can agree that the Loadout should consist of 15 cards instead of 10.
- Example: You can adjust the overall number of character abilities to start higher than 5 and end higher than 23.
- Example: You can abandon the battlemat and design all Abilities for theater-of-the-mind play.
- Example: You can adapt Source Abilities from numerous other TTRPG systems, beyond D&D 5E.
- Example: You can adapt OSK to many other genres besides Medieval Fantasy (such as sci-fi, or modern tactical shooter).
- Example: You can adapt OSK to non-TTRPG games, such as board games.
- However, changing a guideline should be deliberate. Understand what problem the rule was intended to solve before removing it.
- Above all, preserve OSK's core priorities: quick resolution, readable abilities, meaningful choices, flexible character concepts, and cooperative judgment.

ABOUT ABILITY PARAMETERS AND BALANCE:

- Every Designed Ability is made up of several mechanical parameters that determine what it can do, how reliably it works, and how powerful it is.
- Think of an Ability's parameters as adjustable "dials" that can be tuned until an Ability is balanced.
- Increasing one parameter will often require weakening another in order to keep the Ability balanced.
- For example, increasing range, number of targets, area of effect, reliability, or secondary effects may justify lowering damage.
- Likewise, adding meaningful risk, setup requirements, weaker partial results, or other limitations may justify increasing an Ability's power elsewhere.
- There is no universal mathematical formula for balancing every possible Ability.
- Instead, compare the Ability as a whole to its Source Ability, consider the interaction between its parameters, and make a good-faith judgment about whether its benefits and limitations are appropriate for its Level.
- As a general rule, the parameters of a Designed Ability should be roughly similar to those of its Source Ability. (Remember: the Source Abilities were balanced by professional game developers!)
- The goal is not mathematical perfection. The goal is to create Abilities that are powerful enough to be exciting, limited enough to create meaningful choices, and simple enough to resolve quickly during play.

EXAMPLE ABILITY PARAMETERS:

- The major parameters include (but are not limited to):
 - Damage Tier: How much raw damage the Ability deals.
 - Damage Type: What kind of damage the Ability inflicts.
 - Range: How far away the Ability can affect a target.
 - Number of Targets: How many creatures or objects it can affect.
 - Area of Effect: How large an area the Ability can influence.
 - Cooldown: Whether the Ability must cycle through the Cooldown Queue before reuse.
 - Resolution Method: Whether the Ability uses an Attack Roll, Saving Throw, Check, or another method.
 - Reliability: How consistently the Ability produces its strongest result.
 - Duration: How long the Ability's effects remain active.
 - Buffs / Debuffs: Beneficial secondary effects granted to yourself or allies, or harmful secondary effects imposed on enemies.
 - Movement: How much repositioning the Ability grants or forces.
 - Risk: What danger, cost, or drawback the user accepts.
- Some examples: Increasing range may justify lowering damage; Reducing reliability may justify a stronger successful result; Adding a powerful debuff may be justified by removing damage entirely.

HARD BOUNDARIES:

- Designed Abilities generally should not directly modify a character's permanent Attributes or Skills.
- If a Source Ability improves an Attribute or Skill temporarily, its OSK equivalent should generally grant Advantage or another situational benefit instead.
- Abilities should generally avoid rewriting universal systems when a simpler effect can accomplish the same fantasy.
- Abilities must never modify the party's Level, or Armor Class.

ABILITY DAMAGE TIERS:

- Ability damage is organized into five Damage Tiers.
- Damage Tier represents the approximate amount of raw damage an Ability is allowed to devote to wounding a target.
- The more substantial secondary benefits an Ability has, the lower its Damage Tier should generally be.
- Relevant benefits include Range, Area of Effect, multiple Targets, Buffs, Debuffs, mobility, reliability, lasting effects, etc
- Tier 5: Pure or nearly pure damage. Usually close-range, single-target, and without meaningful secondary effects.
- Tier 4: Primarily damage, with modest Range, flexibility, or secondary benefits.
- Tier 3: Moderate damage combined with useful Range, Area, utility, or a meaningful secondary effect.
- Tier 2: Low damage combined with strong Range, several Targets, substantial Area, or a significant secondary effect.
- Tier 1: Token damage attached to an Ability whose primary value is control, support, utility, or other effect. Also frequently used for Under-AC damage.
- Abilities whose non-damage effect is already powerful enough on its own should deal no damage. For example, an Ability that paralyzes an enemy generally should not also inflict damage.
- Abilities should always use a lower Damage Tier on an Under-AC result (or an Enemy-Succeeds-On-Save result) than on an Over-AC result (or an Enemy-Fails-Save result).

- The Damage Tier table is based on the character's current Level:

The Damage Tier table is based on the character's current Level:

Level	Tier 1	Tier 2	Tier 3	Tier 4	Tier 5
1	1d6+1	2d6+2	3d6+5	4d6+6	5d6+8
2	1d6+2	2d6+4	3d6+6	4d6+7	5d6+10
3	2d6+4	3d6+5	4d6+7	5d6+9	6d6+11
4	2d6+5	3d6+7	4d6+9	5d6+10	6d6+12
5	3d6+7	4d6+8	5d6+10	6d6+12	7d6+14
6	3d6+8	4d6+10	5d6+12	6d6+13	7d6+15
7	4d6+10	5d6+11	6d6+13	7d6+14	8d6+17
8	4d6+11	5d6+12	6d6+14	7d6+16	8d6+18
9	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	Nova
10	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	Nova

DAMAGE TIERS ARE GUIDELINES:

- Damage Tiers are balancing tools. The correct Tier depends on the entire Ability rather than any single parameter.
- Two Abilities with the same range and number of targets may deserve different Damage Tiers because one has a stronger secondary effect, greater reliability, or harsher drawback.
- Do not increase an Ability's Damage merely because its concept sounds especially dramatic.
- Instead, preserve that fantasy through its description, effects, risks, or other parameters.

ABILITY RANGES:

- A card must state its Range whenever it targets something other than the user. Range is measured in squares on the combat grid.
- Melee Abilities normally target an adjacent square.
- Ranged Abilities state the maximum number of squares they can reach.
- A target outside the listed Range cannot normally be affected.
- Longer Range is a significant advantage and may justify lower Damage, fewer Targets, weaker secondary effects, or another limitation.
- If an Ability affects an Area, its Range determines where that Area may be placed unless the card states otherwise.
- Abilities that require Line of Sight still follow the normal Line of Sight and Cover rules.

AREA-OF-EFFECT SHAPES:

- OSK uses simple grid-based Areas of Effect. The standard shapes are lines, grids, and cubes.
- A line is a continuous series of squares extending in a direction.
- A grid is an X-by-Y two-dimensional area.
- A cube is an X-by-Y-by-Z three-dimensional area.
- OSK DOES NOT use circles, spheres, or cones. If a Source Ability uses those shapes, convert them into lines, grids, or cubes.
- When converting an area from another system, preserve its approximate practical size rather than obsessing over perfect mathematical equivalence. Exact geometric equivalence is less important than clarity and speed at the table.

ABILITY BALANCING GUIDELINES:

- There is no universal equation for determining whether an Ability is balanced.
- Instead, compare its benefits and limitations as a whole. In general, the more benefits an ability has (such as long range, or multiple targets), the less damage it should do.
- Ask:
 - What is the underlying fantasy or vibe of the Source Ability?
 - Is its primary function damage, healing, control, movement, defense, support, utility, or something else entirely?
 - How many targets can it affect?
 - What is its maximum range?
 - How large is its area-of-effect?
 - How reliably does it work?
 - Does it impose a lasting effect?
 - Should it require Cooldown?
 - Does it require positioning, setup, risk, or another limitation?
 - What happens when the Attack Roll is Under-AC, or if Enemy-Succeeds-On-Saving-Throw?
 - How powerful is the Source Ability relative to other abilities available at the same point in its original game?
 - What Damage Tier, if any, remains appropriate after accounting for everything else?
 - Would the Ability still feel reasonably fair if an enemy combatant used it against the player characters?

- Example: a melee axe attack may reasonably deal more raw damage than a long-range bow attack because the melee combatant accepts the positional risk of being adjacent to an enemy.
- However, the fantasy/vibe of the Ability still matters!
- Example: A devastating blunderbuss attack may deserve exceptionally high Over-AC damage despite being ranged. Its limitation might instead be extremely weak Under-AC damage, or another drawback (such as the potential of a gun jam).
- Example: An Ability based on a spell that paralyzes a target should not then add damage, simply because damage is available as a parameter. To both paralyze AND damage an enemy would risk the ability being unbalanced and overpowered.
- Ability creation is not about achieving mathematical perfection. It is about preserving the desired fantasy while making a good-faith effort to create an option that fits into the rest of the game.
- Finally, remember that the GM has final authority over Ability balance.
- If an Ability proves to be too strong, too vague, too disruptive to pacing, or otherwise problematic - it must be reworked.

BOOSTING ABILITY OUTPUT:

- Some Source Abilities can increase their output by consuming additional resources than normal.
- With Recovery Points as the only resource that suffers from attrition, there is no direct equivalent in OSK.
- However, Designed Abilities may still allow increased output if the stronger effect carries an appropriate additional cost, beyond being placed into the Cooldown Queue.
- Possible costs include:
 - Losing HP
 - Spending a Recovery Point
 - Accepting a Condition
 - Reducing the Ability's reliability
 - Increasing personal risk
 - Sacrificing another benefit
- For example, a healing ability might be designed to allow the character to heal a greater number of HP on an ally than normal by sacrificing some of their own HP, or one of their own Recovery Points.
- Avoid introducing a new resource counter solely to support an Ability unless the group deliberately wants that added bookkeeping.

ABOUT ABILITY TYPES:

- TTRPG designers and players have been inventing character abilities since the earliest days of the hobby in the 1970s.
- Human creativity has always been one of the driving forces behind tabletop roleplaying games, and new mechanical ideas continue to appear constantly.
- For that reason, it would be impossible to create a truly exhaustive list of every possible type of Ability.
- The categories in this chapter instead cover common Ability types and recurring design problems that are especially useful to consider when creating OSK cards.
- The purpose of these categories is not to restrict creativity, but rather to identify common design problems and suggest simple solutions.

TYPES OF ABILITIES TO AVOID:

- OSK explicitly discourages Abilities that trivialize large categories of challenges.
- Examples include unrestricted global teleportation, automatic solutions to mysteries, permanent immunity to common hazards, or effects capable of rewriting reality at will.
- D&D's Wish spell is arguably the most extreme example of these types of problematic abilities.
- Effects of this scale are generally better treated as artifacts, unique Equipment, story rewards, or GM-controlled phenomena rather than ordinary Designed Abilities.
- Whether such effects should exist at all is ultimately the decision of the GM and the group, collectively.
- OSK also discourages Abilities that employ sustained mind-control effects without the target's consent. This is for two reasons:
 - First, these types of abilities can create situations that many players find ethically dubious, even within the context of the game. They may cause certain players a great deal of discomfort at the table.
 - Second, if these types of abilities are turned on the players themselves, those players may chafe at the loss of agency over their character.
- Avoid designing Abilities that modify core game rules in fundamental ways.
- Avoid designing Abilities that modify Wealth, Level, or Character Stats.
- Avoid designing Abilities that significantly slow down play.

- Avoid designing Abilities that require long calculations, repeated rerolls, large amounts of tracking, or recalculation of statistics.
- Avoid designing Abilities whose effects are substantially broader than their Source Ability without gaining meaningful new limitations.
- Avoid designing Abilities primarily to exploit a technical loophole rather than create an interesting game option.

HYBRID ABILITIES:

- Many Abilities can fit into more than one category.
- For example, an Ability may deal Damage while also inflicting a Debuff, or Transform the user while granting Passive effects.
- When an Ability combines multiple functions, consider the balance implications of all of them together.
- An Ability that performs several functions should generally perform each individual function less strongly than a specialized Ability.
- Do not judge only the Ability's most obvious effect when balancing it - consider it as a complete package.

[ABILITY TYPE] DAMAGE:

- Damage Abilities are the simplest and most basic type of combat Ability. Their primary purpose is reducing enemy HP.
- Use the Damage Tier system described in the previous chapter.
- A damage Ability with few secondary benefits may use a high Damage Tier. As range, area of effect, number of targets, reliability, buffs, debuffs, conditions, or other riders increase, Damage Tier should generally decrease.
- Tier 5 should usually be reserved for Abilities whose primary advantage is simply dealing large amounts of damage.
- An Ability may deal different Damage Tiers depending on its result. For example: Over-AC = Tier 5 Physical damage / Under-AC = Tier 3 Physical damage.
- High-risk Abilities may use a much greater difference between successful and unsuccessful results.
- Damage Type usually has relatively little effect on an Ability's raw power unless vulnerabilities, resistances, or immunities make that type particularly significant in that combat.
- Do not add unnecessary secondary effects merely because there is room on the card.

[ABILITY TYPE] HEALING:

- Healing restores lost HP. Any time a character regains any amount of HP, they mark off one Recovery Point.
- Healing Abilities should not bypass this requirement.
- Healing Abilities should often - though not necessarily always - base the amount healed on the Damage Tier chart. However healing Abilities should rarely - if ever - use the highest Damage Tiers for healing.
- Balance consideration: Healing several allies at once should generally restore less HP to each individual target than a single-target heal.
- Balance consideration: Long-range healing is more useful than adjacent healing and should be balanced accordingly by healing at a lower Damage Tier.
- Balance consideration: Healing Abilities that also remove conditions, grant Temporary HP, provide movement, or create another benefit should also generally heal less.

[ABILITY TYPE] BUFF / DEBUFF:

- Buffs improve an ally's capabilities. Debuffs hinder an enemy's capabilities.
- Common Buffs include granting Advantage, extra Movement, Temporary HP, protection from a Damage Type, or improvements to a specific kind of Action.
- Common Debuffs include causing Disadvantage, reduced Movement, or forced movement.
- Strong Buffs and Debuffs should usually have limited Duration. An effect that lasts while its card remains in the Cooldown Queue is often an appropriate default.
- Effects that substantially restrict an enemy's Actions or Movement should generally deal little or no damage.
- Effects that completely prevent an enemy from acting (such as paralysis) are extremely powerful and should require significant limitations.
- Debuffs should normally allow some meaningful method of resolution for the target, such as an Attack Roll, Saving Throw, limited Duration, or specific circumstance.

[ABILITY TYPE] MOVEMENT:

- Movement Abilities change a character's position beyond ordinary Movement Actions.
- Examples include dashes, leaps, teleportation, charges, grappling hooks, short flights, burrowing, or magical repositioning.
- Movement that merely relocates the user a short distance may require little or no tradeoffs. Movement that ignores enemies, walls, terrain, elevation, or other obstacles is significantly more powerful.
- Abilities such as teleportation should have a clearly defined maximum Range.

[ABILITY TYPE] PASSIVE ABILITIES:

- Passive Abilities function continuously while their cards remain in the character's Loadout. They do not normally require an Action, nor do they enter the Cooldown Queue. And their effects cease immediately when they leave the Loadout.
- Because Passive Abilities require no Action and can function repeatedly, they should generally be weaker than comparable activated Abilities.
- Passives are well suited for narrow bonuses, situational benefits, unusual movement options, minor defenses, or modifications to specific types of Abilities.
- Avoid Passives that provide broad Advantage on large categories of rolls.
- Avoid Passive effects that substantially increase damage on nearly every attack.
- Avoid Passive Abilities that make another card strictly superior with no meaningful opportunity cost.
- The Loadout slot itself is part of a Passive Ability's cost, but this alone does not justify an exceptionally strong permanent benefit.

[ABILITY TYPE] HP INCREASE:

- Some Abilities may increase a character's maximum HP.
- Maximum HP increases should be considered carefully because they provide a constant defensive benefit without requiring an Action.
- A single Ability should generally increase maximum HP by no more than approximately 10-25% of the character's normal maximum HP.
- A character's total maximum HP from Ability and Equipment bonuses should generally not exceed approximately 50% above their normal baseline.
- The exact limits may be adjusted by the GM depending on campaign balance.
- HP increases should normally use either a fixed amount determined by Level or a simple percentage. Avoid effects that repeatedly recalculate HP based on changing Attributes or temporary effects.
- If special armor, shields, or magical protection are intended to increase survivability, it should increase HP. Abilities SHOULD NOT attempt to modify the team's AC.

[ABILITY TYPE] UTILITY / NON-COMBAT:

- Utility Abilities solve problems without primarily dealing damage.
- Examples include magical manipulation, creating light, communicating at unusual distances, disguising appearances, manipulating objects, detecting supernatural effects, or interacting with the environment.
- Minor utility effects may not require Cooldown if their consequences are small. Examples include effects similar in scope to D&D spells such as Mage Hand, Prestidigitation, Druidcraft, or Thaumaturgy.
- Broad utility should still have meaningful boundaries.
- An Ability may allow you to manipulate a distant object without allowing unlimited telekinesis.
- An Ability may detect magical influence without automatically explaining exactly what every magical object does.
- Utility Abilities should create additional options rather than automatically bypassing entire categories of obstacles.
- The GM may still call for a Check when the outcome remains uncertain despite the Ability.

[ABILITY TYPE] DEFENSIVE / PROTECTIVE:

- Defensive Abilities reduce, redirect, avoid, or absorb incoming harm.
- In OSK, these abilities DO NOT modify the team's shared Armor Class.
- Instead, defensive effects should use mechanics such as temporary HP, resistance, advantage or disadvantage, damage reduction, or protection against specific effects.
- A defensive Ability that completely negates an attack should usually require a meaningful cost, limitation, or trigger, as well as cooldown.
- Broad resistance to many damage types is substantially stronger than resistance to one narrow type.
- Defensive Abilities should not make a character functionally untouchable for extended periods. Never grant permanent or long-lasting immunity to common damage types.

[ABILITY TYPE] CONTROL:

- Control Abilities manipulate positioning, actions, movement, or battlefield access.
- Examples include creating barriers, blocking terrain, or preventing movement.
- Control often has greater tactical value than raw damage. Strong control effects should therefore deal little or no damage.
- Do not employ effects that completely remove a target's ability to participate in combat. Use temporary or conditional control, rather than indefinite effects.
- Terrain created by an Ability should use simple shapes and clearly state how long it lasts. Avoid creating large numbers of persistent battlefield objects that require extensive tracking.

[ABILITY TYPE] TRANSFORMATIONS:

- Transformation Abilities allow a character to assume another form or state.
- Examples include shapeshifting into an animal, lycanthropic transformations, magical battle forms, powered armor modes, or other supernatural metamorphosis.
- Transformations should not replace the character with an entirely separate character sheet. Instead, preserve the character's existing statistics and modify only a few important characteristics.
- A transformation may grant: additional HP or temporary HP, different Movement, new attack options, passive benefits, or damage resistance.
- Transformations must be designed carefully because they can potentially provide numerous benefits simultaneously. The more benefits a transformation grants, the greater its limitations should be.
- Possible limitations include: cooldown, once-per-Rest use, spending a Recovery Point, limited duration, restrictions on which existing cards can be used, self-damage, or reduced utility outside the transformation's intended role.
- Transformations must also fit the fantasy of your character. A character who otherwise has no magical powers should (generally) not suddenly gain the ability to shapeshift into animals.
- As with all Abilities, transformations must be designed in good faith. Do not use them to create permanent go-to solutions for a wide range of common problems.

[ABILITY TYPE] SUMMONING:

- Summoning Abilities create or call another creature, construct, spirit, familiar, companion, or similar entity.
- Summons are potentially powerful because they can add additional Abilities, bodies, HP, positioning, and tactical options. For this reason, summoned creatures should be kept mechanically simple.
- A summon should generally not use a full player-character ruleset. Whenever possible, summarize the summon on the Ability card itself or on one additional reference card.
- A summon may have: a simple HP value, Movement, and a small number of special actions or traits.
- A summon should always act on the summoner's turn, rather than receiving an entirely separate place in Initiative.
- Commanding the summon be done by using the summoner's Actions; summons should NOT have access to their own, separate Actions.
- A summoner should generally not maintain several independent summoned creatures simultaneously.
- Large groups of minor creatures should usually be represented as a single swarm or unit rather than many separate combatants.
- A summon should disappear when its duration ends, when the summoner reaches 0 HP, when the summon itself reaches 0 HP, or when another stated condition occurs.

[ABILITY TYPE] INFORMATION / DIVINATION:

- Information-gathering or Divination Abilities reveal facts or clues that would otherwise be hidden.
- Examples include detecting magic, sensing creatures, reading omens, locating objects, supernatural investigation, or communicating with distant entities.
- Information is often more powerful than it initially appears because it can bypass exploration, investigation, mystery, or social challenges.
- Information Abilities should generally answer narrow questions rather than provide complete explanations.
- Do not design Abilities that automatically reveal everything necessary to solve a mystery or avoid every ambush. The stronger and more reliable the information, the narrower its scope should generally be.

[ABILITY TYPE] RESURRECTION:

- Resurrection returns a dead character to life.
- This is one of the most powerful effects available in most fantasy TTRPGs. Resurrection should therefore carry substantial limitations.
- Possible limitations include: requiring the healer to spend their own Recovery Points, a difficult ritual, expensive or unusual materials, a permanent consequence, a difficult Check, or a major story requirement.
- Limitations on frequency of usage are also highly reasonable. For some groups and campaigns, once-per-long-rest may be appropriate; for others, once-per-week, once-per-year, or once-per-decade or more may make more sense.
- Effects that merely stabilize a dying character are not resurrection, and should be considerably easier to access (typically through standard Medicine checks).
- Resurrection abilities are sufficiently powerful that they should not be combined with any other effects, such as healing other allies or damaging enemies simultaneously.
- Resurrection should generally not become a routine combat healing option. Resurrection during combat should be extremely rare, and the tradeoffs should be extremely costly.
- Low-Level Designed Abilities should not normally provide unrestricted resurrection, though they may provide resurrection in specific, narrowly-scoped situations.
- Remember: a game where permanent death is never really on the table is a game where the threat of failure

loses much of its dramatic tension because the consequences no longer feel permanent or meaningful.

- Ultimately, the availability and narrative consequences of resurrection should match the tone of the campaign in accordance with the collective wishes of the GM and the group.

[ABILITY TYPE] NOVA:

- Nova Abilities are exceptional Abilities gained at Levels 9 and 10.
- Nova Abilities are intentionally dramatic and may break rules that normal Designed Abilities should respect. They do not use the ordinary Damage Tier structure.
- Examples may include enormous attacks, battlefield-wide effects, extreme transformations, mass healing, devastating control, or other character-defining powers.
- Nova does not mean unlimited. A Nova Ability should have clearly defined mechanics and should still resolve quickly. They should still be resolved within the scope of a single Action.
- By default, Nova Abilities may be used once per Long Rest. However, as with Resurrection Abilities, longer frequency-of-usage limitations may be warranted.
- Some Nova Abilities may require additional costs or limitations if their effects are especially broad.
- Nova Abilities may: bypass the ordinary pattern used in Damage Tiers, affect unusually large areas, target many creatures, create unusually powerful Buffs or Debuffs, create dramatic transformations, or prevent catastrophic harm.
- Even Nova Abilities should generally avoid permanently solving every future problem of a particular type.
- A Nova should feel like an extraordinary moment, not a permanent and instantaneous rewrite to a major campaign challenge.

Chapter 12: Equipment & Consumables

EQUIPMENT:

- Equipment cards represent reusable gear, such as special weapons, armor, and other tools.
- Only unusual, specialized, or mechanically important items require their own Equipment card.
- Mundane clothing, weapons, tools, and supplies can usually be either grouped together on a single Equipment card, or simply written down as un-carded equipment.
- Some Equipment cards are activated similarly to Ability cards, by taking the Use Equipment action.
- Activating Equipment in combat may involve an Attack Roll, Saving Throw, Check, movement, damage, or another effect.

EQUIPMENT IN YOUR LOADOUT:

- An Equipment card usually must be in your Loadout for you to benefit from it during combat.
- Equipment in your Deck is carried by your character, but is not immediately available for use.
- Equipment can be swapped between your Deck and Loadout through the Reconfigure action.

EQUIPMENT COOLDOWN:

- Like most Ability cards, some Equipment cards require Cooldown after they are activated.
- When used, place the Equipment card into Cooldown Slot 1. The card moves through the Cooldown Queue normally.
- Equipment that does not say it requires Cooldown simply remains in the Loadout after use.

COMBO EQUIPMENT:

- Some Equipment cards have the Combo trait. A Combo Equipment card may enter Cooldown Slot 1 in addition to one other card used during the same turn.
- The Combo card may be placed above or below the other card, depending on which card was used first.
- A Combo card still requires a Use Equipment Action unless stated otherwise.
- For more rules on the Combo trait and the Cooldown Queue, see Chapter XX.

EQUIPMENT THAT MODIFIES ABILITIES:

- Equipment may modify compatible Ability cards while it remains in your Loadout.
- However, Equipment whose primary purpose is modifying Abilities should generally also have its own independent Ability-like effect as well.
- This prevents the Equipment from becoming useless while its compatible Abilities are unavailable in the Cooldown Queue.
- For example, a magical fire sword might add fire damage to melee-based Abilities, while also providing its own attack when activated with the Use Equipment Action.
- These Ability-like effects may justify a Cooldown themselves, but that should NOT prevent the Equipment's passive effects from working as normal.
- Many types of Equipment (such as armor, tools, and other primarily passive items) may reasonably have no Ability-like use.

PASSIVE EQUIPMENT:

- Passive Equipment provides a continuous benefit while it remains in your Loadout. It does not require an Action to activate.
- Its benefit ends immediately if the card leaves your Loadout.
- Passive Equipment should clearly state what benefit it provides.

WEAPONS, ARMOR AND SHIELDS:

- Ordinary weapons do not have universal damage dice. The damage and effects of an attack are determined primarily by the Ability being used.
- A weapon may be part of an Ability's description without requiring its own Equipment card.
- Unusual, magical, advanced, or especially powerful weapons may have Equipment cards.
- Ordinary armor and shields are already represented by the team's shared Armor Class. They do not require separate Equipment cards.
- Special armor and shields generally do require Equipment cards. They may provide passive benefits or activated effects.
- Special armor and shields SHOULD NOT modify the team's Armor Class. Instead, they should provide a boost to the character's Hit Points.
- Shields can also be used as part of a Wildcard action, such as bashing an enemy in the face, or sledding down stairs while shooting orcs with a bow.

PACKS AND KITS:

- A Pack or Kit represents a collection of related mundane gear. Packs and Kits can be represented by a single Equipment card.
- Examples include an adventuring pack, healer's kit, climbing kit, disguise kit, or artisan's tools.
- The player and Game Master should use common sense when deciding whether a reasonable item is included.
- Rare, expensive, magical, or unusually powerful items should be tracked separately.

FOUND EQUIPMENT:

- Characters may find or acquire Equipment during play.
- Unless the Equipment is mundane or inconsequential enough to be un-carded, a newly acquired item is added to the character's Deck.
- During combat, a character can place a newly-acquired item directly into their Loadout. (If it causes the player's Loadout to go beyond 10, the player must move one card into their Deck.)
- An unfamiliar item may require a familiarization, analysis, activation, or special instruction before it can be used effectively.

UN-CARDED EQUIPMENT:

- Trivial, mundane, or inconsequential minor items may not require a full Equipment card. The player can simply make a note that they've acquired the item.
- Examples include small trinkets, low-value gems, everyday utensils, edible fruits, etc.

EQUIPMENT LIMITATIONS:

- OSK generally avoids tracking mundane ammunition, such as arrows.
- However, certain kinds of special Equipment may require ammunition, fuel, charges, two hands, a free hand, a specific environment, or something else in order to be usable.
- Any important limitation should be written on the Equipment card.
- Certain limitations, such as special ammunition, may be represented by Consumable cards in addition to the corresponding Equipment card.

DESIGNING EQUIPMENT CARDS:

- Like Ability cards, Equipment cards should be concise and fit on a 3x5 card.
- The card should state whether it is Activated, Passive, Combo, Consumable, or Requires Cooldown. The card should also define any compatible Abilities, range, targets, rolls, effects, and limitations.
- Equipment should be balanced using principles similar to Ability design (see Chapter XX). In other words, equipment that grants a broad or permanent benefit should generally be weaker than a comparable activated effect.
- The GM may revise Equipment that proves unclear, disruptive, or unbalanced.

CONSUMABLES:

- Consumables are one-time-use items, represented by Consumable cards.
- Examples include potions, scrolls, special ammunition, alchemical mixtures, poisons, and enchanted food.
- After a Consumable is used, remove its card from the character's Deck.

USING CONSUMABLES:

- Activating a Consumable normally requires a Use Consumable action. Consumables usually do not enter the Cooldown Queue.
- Unless the card states otherwise, a consumable must be in your Loadout in order to use it. After you've used it, you can immediately swap a new card from your Deck into your Loadout.
- A Consumable may be used on yourself, an adjacent creature, or another valid target described by the card.
- Throwable, offensive Consumables may require an Attack Roll, Check, or defined area of effect.

CONSUMABLE EFFECTS:

- Consumables may restore HP, grant Temporary HP, remove Conditions, modify Abilities, create environmental effects, or produce other benefits.
- A Consumable should state any relevant secondary information, such as range, target, duration, required rolls, etc.
- Healing Consumables still require the target to spend a Recovery Point, unless the card specifically says otherwise.
- Exceptionally powerful Consumables (such as ones that restore Recovery Points or resurrect dead allies) should generally be extraordinarily rare.

Chapter 13: For the GM – Running the Game

THE GAME MASTER'S ROLE

- The GM describes the world, portrays its inhabitants, presents challenges, controls enemies, and decides how the rules apply when the outcome of an action is uncertain.
- The GM is not the players' opponent. Your goal is not to defeat the player characters.
- Your goal is to present situations where their decisions matter, their abilities are useful, their mistakes have consequences, and everyone at the table has an enjoyable game.
- You are also not responsible for determining the story's outcome in advance.
- Present situations, people, dangers, opportunities, and consequences. Allow the players' decisions and the dice to determine what happens next.
- OSK gives the GM substantial authority. Use that authority to keep the game moving, preserve the agreed tone of the campaign, and make reasonable judgments when unusual situations arise.
- You will occasionally make the wrong call. That is totally fine! It is a natural part of learning and running the game.
- Make the best ruling you can, continue playing, and reconsider it later if necessary.

RULINGS, NOT RULES

- OSK deliberately does not contain a detailed rule for every possible situation.
- When a situation is not covered by an explicit rule, use common sense, the established fiction, and the existing mechanics to make a ruling.
- The GM has final authority in these situations.
- Ask questions about these situations, such as:
 - What is the character attempting to accomplish?
 - Does it make sense in the current situation?
 - Is the outcome uncertain?
 - Is there already a mechanic that can resolve it?
 - What would be a reasonable consequence of success or failure?
- Whenever possible, resolve unusual situations with existing tools (such as: Skill Checks, Saving Throws, Contested Checks, Advantage/Disadvantage, Improvised Damage, and Conditions).
- Consistency is useful, but consistency should not become a straightjacket. A ruling made during one unusual situation does not automatically become a permanent universal rule. Circumstances may differ.
- If a ruling is likely to recur frequently, make a note of it and discuss it with the group between sessions.
- It is not necessary to spend ten minutes searching through rules in order to make a perfect ruling. Simply make the ruling with your best judgment and continue playing. This is how the game is intended to work!

CALLING FOR CHECKS:

- Do not call for a Check merely because a character attempts to do something.
- Call for a Check when: (1) The outcome is uncertain, (2) Success and failure are both reasonably possible, and (3) Failure would have a meaningful consequence.
- If an action is trivial under the circumstances, simply allow it to succeed.
- If an action is genuinely impossible, simply say that it cannot work. A Natural 20 does not allow a character to accomplish something that is physically, logically, or narratively impossible.
- Likewise, avoid using Checks to withhold information or accomplishments that characters should reasonably receive automatically.
- For example, if a professional blacksmith examines an ordinary sword, they probably do not need to roll to recognize that it is poorly made.
- Skills in OSK are deliberately broad and are not permanently tied to specific Attributes.
- Choose whichever Skill, Attribute, or other modifier best represents what the character is actually doing. If two different approaches would reasonably work, you may allow the player to choose between them.
- Avoid calling for rolls excessively or repeatedly. Repeated Checks for essentially the same task usually slow the game without improving it.
- For example, if a character succeeds on a Check to climb a difficult wall, they generally do not need to make another Check every few feet unless the circumstances materially change.

DETERMINING DCs:

- A Difficulty Class represents how difficult a task is to accomplish under the current circumstances. Lower DCs represent easier tasks. Higher DCs represent harder tasks.
- A useful general scale is:
 - DC 05: Very easy
 - DC 15: Moderately difficult
 - DC 20: Difficult
 - DC 30: Extraordinarily difficult
- These numbers are guidelines rather than rigid categories.
- For example, climbing a rough stone wall might be approximately DC 10, while climbing a sheer wall covered in ice might be approximately DC 25.
- DCs generally should not exceed 30. Beyond that, strongly consider whether the task is simply impossible under the current circumstances.
- Do not increase the DC merely because a particular character has a high modifier. A DC describes the difficulty of the task, not the character attempting it.
- For example, the same locked door should not mysteriously become harder to pick because the group's expert thief is standing in front of it.
- Characters invested Skill Points specifically so that they could become exceptionally competent. So let them be exceptionally competent!
- When circumstances make a task substantially easier or harder, you can change the DC. Alternatively, you can simply grant Advantage or Disadvantage.

- For example: Climbing during a violent storm may impose Disadvantage; Using excellent climbing equipment may grant Advantage; Attempting the climb while both conditions apply may cause the Adv/Disadv to cancel each other out!
- Use whichever approach is easiest to adjudicate and understand.

PACING:

- Pacing is the rate at which meaningful things happen during the game.
- Good pacing does not mean that everything must happen quickly. A tense negotiation, emotional conversation, mystery, or tactical decision may deserve substantial time.
- The important question is whether the players are engaged with what is happening.
- When a scene has accomplished its purpose, move forward.
- Likewise, if the players are deeply engaged with an unexpected scene, you do not need to cut it short merely because it was not in your preparation.
- Watch for stagnation. A scene may be stalling if:
 - The players are repeatedly discussing the same possibilities.
 - Nobody knows what information they are missing.
 - The group believes there is one specific solution but cannot find it.
 - The characters have already succeeded but play has not moved forward.
 - A player has been unable to meaningfully participate for an extended period.
- When this happens, introduce information, clarify the situation, summarize uneventful activity, change the circumstances, or simply find an excuse to move forward.
- As the GM, you control the fundamental flow of information at the table.

SESSION ZERO:

- A Session Zero is a discussion held before normal campaign play begins. It is a **VERY STRONGLY RECOMMENDED** practice!
- Because players can create their own Abilities and adapt material from other games, the group should establish expectations before character creation.
- Discussion topics can include:
 - The campaign's setting
 - The campaign's tone
 - The general premise
 - What kinds of characters fit the campaign
 - Permitted Classes and Species
 - Permitted source material
 - Whether material from other TTRPGs may be used when designing Abilities
 - Expected Ability complexity
 - Expected power level
 - Character relationships and group cohesion
 - Subjects the group does not want included
 - Any house rules or modified OSK rules
 - How frequently the group expects to play
 - How absent players will be handled
 - Whether characters can die permanently
 - How resurrection works, if relevant
 - Any campaign-specific boundaries
- The GM should explain significant restrictions before players invest time designing characters.
- Example: If firearms do not exist in the setting, say so before somebody builds an entire gunslinger.
- Example: If teleportation magic fundamentally conflicts with the campaign premise, establish that

boundary before somebody creates a teleportation specialist.

- Session Zero does not permanently settle every question. The group may discover during play that an expectation, rule, Ability, or boundary is not working as intended.
- Revisions like these are a normal part of the game! Simply discuss the issue, and make adjustments as necessary.

SESSION PREPARATION:

- Remember that as the GM, your job is to prepare situations for the players to interact with, and NOT to prepare scripts with predetermined outcomes!
- You generally need to know:
 - Where the characters are
 - What is currently happening
 - Who or what is involved
 - What important NPCs want
 - What threats or opportunities exist
 - What may happen if the characters do nothing
 - What information the characters can discover
 - What combatants or stat blocks might reasonably be needed
- It's impossible to predict exactly what the players will do. If your preparation only works when the players make one specific sequence of decisions, then it is problematically fragile.
- Instead, understand the situation well enough that you can determine how it reacts. Preparation is most valuable when it helps you improvise.
- Do not prepare twenty pages of material merely because you feel that a GM is supposed to. You only need to prepare what helps you run the game!

RESTING AND ATTRITION:

- A normal Long Rest (also simply called a Rest) requires approximately 8–12 hours and restores HP and Recovery Points. (There are no "short rests" in OSK.)
- Recovery Points are the game's primary attrition resource. Every time a character regains HP, they normally spend one Recovery Point, regardless of the amount healed.
- As a result, the long-term danger of multiple encounters is not merely losing HP - it is losing the ability to recover HP.
- Rests should follow the fiction. Do not prevent the characters from Resting merely because you want them to remain depleted.
- Likewise, a Rest is not always automatically possible merely because the players want one.
- Ask whether the characters actually have the time and opportunity to spend 8–12 hours resting.
- If they are sleeping safely in a fortified town, the answer is probably yes. If they stop to sleep in the middle of an actively collapsing fortress while enemies are searching for them....not so much.
- Not every adventure needs to pressure Recovery Points heavily.
- Some adventures may contain one enormous confrontation while the characters are fully rested; others may involve several dangerous situations before a safe Rest becomes practical. Both are valid.
- However, be aware that frequent unrestricted Resting substantially reduces the importance of Recovery

Points. And conversely, constantly denying Rest can make the campaign far more punishing than intended.

- Choose the level of attrition that fits the adventure.
- If Resting will have consequences, give the players enough information to make a meaningful decision.
- For example: "The ritual may be completed by morning", "The kidnappers may relocate", "The army may arrive tomorrow", etc
- The wounded characters can still choose to Rest, but now that choice has a cost they understand.
- Avoid arbitrary "you cannot Rest because the GM says so" restrictions.

NON-COMBAT CHALLENGES:

- OSK does not need a dedicated subsystem for every kind of non-combat activity. Most challenges can be resolved through ordinary description, decisions, Checks, consequences, and GM adjudication.
- Start with the situation. Ask what the players are trying to accomplish. Then determine what actually needs to be resolved mechanically.
- A complex challenge does not necessarily require a complex rule.
- Suppose the characters are attempting to infiltrate a fortified palace. Rather than automatically turning this into ten consecutive Skill Checks, present the actual problems:
 - Guards watch the entrance.
 - Servants enter through another gate.
 - The walls are difficult to climb.
 - An invitation might be forged.
 - A sympathetic noble may be persuaded to help.
- The players choose an approach. Resolve the uncertain parts of that approach. Then update the situation.
- The challenge becomes interesting because of the decisions - NOT simply because of the number of dice rolled!
- Let character Abilities matter! Characters may possess Abilities, Equipment, Species traits, or Skills specifically intended to solve unusual problems. Let them work.
- If a character can breathe underwater, an underwater obstacle should feel different for them. If a character has invested heavily in Language, they should often be able to communicate where others cannot.

- Do not continually invent reasons why a character's defining capabilities fail merely to preserve a challenge you had planned. Instead, allow those capabilities to change the nature of the challenge.

INFORMATION AND CONSEQUENCES:

- Players can only make meaningful decisions using information they possess. Do not deliberately hide obvious information merely to make the game harder.
- Tell players what their characters can plainly perceive, and tell them things their characters would reasonably know.
- If an experienced adventurer would recognize that jumping into a particular chasm is probably fatal, or if a wizard would immediately recognize an elementary magical symbol, be sure to communicate that to your players!
- A Check should usually be used for genuinely uncertain or concealed information - not for basic facts necessary to understand the situation.
- Important information should not have only one path. If the players need a piece of information in order for the adventure to continue, avoid placing it behind one mandatory Check.
- If failure means "the adventure stops," the Check is probably poorly designed.
- Important information may be discoverable through several routes, such as: searching, questioning an NPC, examining an object, following evidence, using an Ability, or applying relevant character knowledge.
- A successful Check may reveal information faster, more completely, or without complications.
- Failure should change the situation rather than erase the possibility of progress.

- You do not need to reveal every hidden consequence, but whenever practical, players should understand the likely stakes of a risky decision before committing to it.
- Do not rely on information the players could not reasonably have known and then punish them for failing to guess it. Consequences feel fair when players can look backward and understand how their choices produced them.

FAILURE, DEGREES OF SUCCESS, AND FAILING FORWARD

- Failure should generally move the game somewhere. A failed Check does not have to mean "Nothing happens, try again."
- Instead, the appropriate result depends on what was being attempted. Failure may mean:
 - The character succeeds, but takes longer than expected.
 - The character succeeds, but attracts unwanted attention.
 - The character gets only part of what they wanted.
 - The character loses an opportunity.
 - The situation becomes more dangerous.
 - An NPC becomes suspicious.
 - Equipment is damaged or lost.
 - The characters reveal information about themselves.
 - The opposition gains an advantage.
 - The character simply fails, and must try a different approach.
- "Failing forward" does not mean characters must eventually succeed at everything.
- Sometimes a locked door remains locked, an NPC refuses to cooperate, the villain escapes, or the characters simply lose.
- The important principle is that the situation should remain capable of changing. Failure creates the next problem.
- Not every Check needs a binary result. Often, using "degrees of success" is more useful: the total of the check may determine the quality of the outcome.

- A character who barely succeeds may accomplish the basic goal, whereas a character who greatly exceeds the DC may accomplish it faster, more thoroughly, more quietly, or with some additional benefit.
- Likewise, a severe failure may create a greater complication than a narrow failure.
- Use this when it adds something meaningful. Do not turn every Check into a complicated table of outcomes.
- Natural 20s and Natural 1s should ALWAYS feel like special results.
- A Natural 20 should normally produce an especially favorable outcome. A Natural 1 should normally produce an especially unfavorable outcome.
- Neither needs to produce absurd, utterly unrealistic results. Keep the result grounded in what the action could reasonably accomplish.

CAMPAIGN-SPECIFIC CHARACTER BOUNDARIES

- OSK intentionally allows an enormous range of character concepts. That does not mean every possible character belongs in every campaign.
- The GM and group should establish boundaries appropriate to the setting, tone, and premise.
- These boundaries may include things such as: allowable Species and Classes, allowable material imported from other TTRPGs, firearms, resurrection, and tone-inappropriate character concepts.
- These restrictions are not inherently limitations on creativity, but rather constraints that help characters feel like they belong in the same world.
- A grim low-magic campaign and a high-fantasy superhero campaign may both use OSK, while permitting radically different character options.
- Whenever possible, state important restrictions and boundaries during Session Zero. Do not allow a player to spend hours designing a character and then announce that their central concept is prohibited.
- Likewise, players should ask before designing around material whose compatibility with the campaign is uncertain.
- Boundaries should have a purpose. Avoid banning options arbitrarily, and explain the reasoning when practical.
- "The campaign takes place in a setting where intercontinental teleportation is impossible" is much easier to work with than "I don't like teleportation."
- A restriction should generally be in service of things such as: The campaign premise, the setting, the

intended tone, mechanical compatibility, table comfort, and preferred style of play.

- Players can then design toward the intended experience rather than trying to guess the GM's preferences.
- OSK is deliberately flexible. Use that flexibility to create the kind of campaign your group actually wants to play.

ENEMY STAT BLOCK COMPOSITION:

- Enemy stat blocks should be fast to read and easy to run. A typical enemy needs:
 - Name
 - Hit Points
 - Movement
 - Combat Modifier / Combat Save DC
 - Vulnerabilities, Resistances, or Immunities (if applicable)
 - Abilities
 - Special rules specific to them
- Do not give enemies player-style character sheets, Decks, Loadouts, or full Designed Ability cards.
- The GM should be able to understand an ordinary enemy's complete turn at a glance.

ENEMY STAT BLOCK DESIGN:

- Start with the Enemy Stat Chart, then change only what makes the creature distinctive.
- Ask questions such as:
 - What is this enemy supposed to do?
 - Is it tough, fragile, mobile, dangerous at range, supportive, controlling, etc?
 - What makes fighting it different from fighting something else?
 - Does that distinction actually need a mechanic?
- Most basic enemies only need 1-3 abilities. More complicated does not automatically mean more interesting.

ENEMY STAT CHART:

- Use the Enemy Stat Chart as the starting point for: HP, Combat Modifier / Combat Save DC, Ability Damage, etc
- The chart represents an ordinary enemy of that approximate power.
- Adjust values to create different enemy types (for example: raising HP and lowering Movement to create a "tank" enemy)
- Enemy Abilities should provide most of the enemy's personality.
- TODO: INCLUDE THE ACTUAL CHART

REFLAVORING ATTACKS:

- You do not need a unique mechanical attack for every weapon, claw, spell, or monster.
- The same mechanical attack can represent a blast of fire, an arrow, a psychic attack, or a flurry of magical ice.
- Remember: Reflavoring is free! Do not create unnecessary mechanical differences simply because two attacks look different in the fiction.

ENEMY DICE USAGE:

- Consider limiting the frequency and number of dice required when enemies attack, in order to keep gameplay moving quickly.
- Whenever practical, use one d20 for an Attack Roll (and avoid several separate attack rolls on one enemy turn).
- Whenever practical, use a static number + 2d6 to calculate damage.
- For example, rather than rolling 7d6, consider a larger static number plus 2d6 (e.g. 18 + 2d6)
- That being said, occasional exceptions can be fun and dramatic! If an ancient dragon breathes fire on your players, rolling 25d6 will certainly get the players' attention!

BOSS STAT BLOCKS:

- Bosses should feel different from ordinary enemies, not merely survive longer.
- A Boss might have: More HP, stronger Abilities, greater mobility, wider area-of-effect abilities, battlefield-changing effects, abilities that change as the battle progresses, etc.
- Avoid simply multiplying HP. A Boss with enormous HP but no evolving tactics becomes a damage sponge.
- Whenever possible, give the Boss something that changes the decisions players make.

MALICE POINTS:

- Malice Points are a GM-facing resource for major enemies and encounters. Special bosses should have between 1 and 5 Malice Points.
- They allow enemies - especially bosses - to use unusually dangerous or dramatic abilities without making those special actions infinitely available.
- The primary purpose of Malice Points is to allow the GM to bend certain combat rules so that a powerful enemy feels appropriately threatening.
- Malice Point effects do not need to be determined in advance - the GM can use them mid-fight and adapt them to whatever the situation calls for.
- General principles:
 - The encounter begins with the appropriate amount of Malice.
 - The GM spends one Malice Point when they want the boss encounter to bend the normal rules of the game.
 - Ordinary attacks should generally not require Malice.
 - Malice should create interesting decisions rather than routine bookkeeping.
 - Malice effects should feel special when they occur.
- Good Malice effects include:
 - Powerfully enhancing an ability for one turn
 - Calling in reinforcements
 - Major battlefield changes
 - Large recoveries of HP
 - Major repositioning out of danger.
 - Cancelling debilitating player abilities

- Avoid Malice effects whose primary purpose is simply preventing players from acting.

REASSESS THE BATTLE AT THE TOP OF EACH ROUND:

- At the beginning of every new Round, briefly reassess the battlefield.
- Ask questions such as:
 - Who is winning?
 - Who is badly wounded?
 - Has the objective changed?
 - Would any enemies flee or surrender?
 - Would reinforcements arrive?
 - Would the enemies change tactics?
 - Has the environment changed?
 - Is the outcome already obvious?
- Do not run enemies like automated game pieces. They should react to what happened during the previous Round.
- If you need to increase the damage output of enemies, consider a narrative explanation (such as having them light their swords on fire, or entering a berzerker frenzy).

HP VS DAMAGE VALUES:

- HP determines how long an enemy remains relevant.
Damage determines how dangerous it feels while alive.
- When adjusting enemy difficulty, remember the following points:
 - More HP: Longer battle.
 - More damage: More dangerous battle.
 - More enemies: More enemy turns and battlefield pressure.
 - Stronger control: Fewer options for the players.
 - Greater mobility: Harder positioning problems.
- These are not equivalent. Be particularly cautious about increasing both HP and damage substantially.
- In general, meaningful danger is preferable over excessive durability.

ENCOUNTER BUILDING:

- When creating a combat encounter, start by asking what the encounter is supposed to accomplish.
- Ask questions like: Why is this combat happening? What do the enemies want? What do the players want? What terrain matters? Is defeating every enemy necessary, or are there alternative objectives?
- Then choose enemies appropriate to that situation.
- Note that enemies can be imported into OSK from various other TTRPGs, in a manner similar to importing Species or Abilities.
- A good encounter often mixes different functions:
 - Durable enemies that occupy space
 - Mobile enemies that pressure vulnerable characters
 - Ranged enemies
 - Support enemies
 - Enemies with unusual Special Abilities
- Do not feel obligated to use every type.
- When judging encounter difficulty, consider things such as:
 - Number of player characters
 - Number of enemies
 - Enemy HP
 - Enemy abilities and damage
 - Battlefield terrain
 - Range
 - The party's current HP and Recovery Points
- Remember: Encounter difficulty is not determined by a single number. The same enemies can be dramatically more dangerous under different circumstances!

ENEMY ACTION ECONOMY:

- The number of enemy combatants greatly effects the overall combat difficulty.
- OSK alternates turns between the Player Team and Enemy Team. Therefore:
 - More enemies usually means more total enemy actions.
 - One powerful enemy may still be disadvantaged against several player characters.
 - Large numbers of weak enemies can become dangerous through action economy alone.
 - Adding enemies changes more than just total HP.
- Be careful when the Enemy Team substantially outnumbers the Player Team.
- Likewise, Bosses may require special rules or Malice abilities to remain threatening when fighting alone.
- Do not compensate for action-economy problems only by adding enormous amounts of HP!

ALTERNATIVE COMBAT OBJECTIVES:

- Not every combat needs to end when one side has reduced the other side to 0 HP. Combat is often more interesting when the participants want something other than simple extermination.
- Possible objectives include:
 - Protect a person
 - Rescue captives
 - Escape an area
 - Prevent enemies from escaping
 - Reach a location
 - Hold a location
 - Capture an enemy alive
 - Steal or recover an object
 - Stop a ritual
 - Destroy a device
 - Survive for a certain number of rounds
 - Delay enemies until help arrives
 - Close a portal
 - Activate several mechanisms
 - Escort someone across the battlefield
 - Prevent destruction of an important object
- Tell the players what their characters can reasonably understand about the objective. An objective cannot meaningfully affect their decisions if they do not know it exists!

ENEMIES HAVE OBJECTIVES TOO:

- Enemy combatants do not necessarily fight until death.
- Bandits may flee after their leader is defeated. Guards may attempt to arrest the characters rather than kill them. Cultists may ignore wounded characters to concentrate on completing a ritual.
- Ask what the enemies actually want. Their tactics should follow from that answer.
- This also gives the GM a natural way to end combats once the important question has been resolved.

ADJUDICATING WILDCARDS:

- Wildcard Actions exist to reward players for interacting creatively with the battlefield (and the other combatants on it).
- When a player proposes a Wildcard:
- Ask what they are trying to accomplish.
- Decide whether it is reasonably possible.
- Choose the simplest resolution.
- Apply a meaningful result.
- Common resolutions include:
 - Skill Checks
 - Contested Checks
 - Saving Throws
 - Granting Advantage or Disadvantage
 - Forced movement
 - Improvised damage
 - Temporary environmental effects
- Wildcards should not simply duplicate another Action or provide an extra attack. Creative Wildcards may receive Advantage.
- Repeated attempts to exploit the same Wildcard may receive Disadvantage or simply stop working when circumstances no longer support them.
- For more information on Wildcard Actions, see Chapter XX.
- Examples:
 - Shoving a bookshelf onto an enemy may cause damage and knock them Prone.
 - Cutting a rope may drop a chandelier.
 - Throwing sand into someone's eyes may briefly impose Disadvantage.

- Smashing a pipe may fill an area with steam.
 - Kicking an enemy off a ledge may cause fall damage.
- Do not require the player to have a card for every clever idea. Instead, favor the fiction. That is what the Wildcard Action is for!

IMPROVISED DAMAGE:

- Use Improvised Damage when something in the environment causes harm but does not have a predefined damage value.
- Examples include: Falling objects, fire, collapsing structures, explosions, dangerous machinery, improvised weapons, environmental hazards
- Improvised damage should be thought of in terms of number of d6 dice rolled. Most improvised damage falls in the 1d6-10d6 range. However, extreme situations may call for far more than 10d6.
- Choose damage based on how dangerous the event actually is.
- Do not overthink exact realism. A falling chandelier does not need calculations involving its mass, acceleration, and ceiling height. Simply decide how dangerous the situation is, roll a reasonable amount of damage, and continue playing.
- Improvised damage does not always happen automatically. Depending on the situation:
 - The attacker and the target may make a contested Check.
 - The target may make a Saving Throw.
 - A successful roll may reduce or avoid the damage.
 - Particularly clever setup may grant Advantage.
- Reward creativity without allowing environmental tricks to become universally superior to Designed Abilities.

ON RUNNING MAJOR VILLAINS:

- A memorable villain is more than an enemy with large amounts of HP. Major villains should want something. They should take actions in pursuit of that goal, whether the player characters are present or not.
- Ask questions like:
 - What does this villain want?
 - Why do they want it?
 - What are they willing to do to obtain it?
 - What resources do they control?
 - What are they afraid of losing?
 - What will they do if the characters interfere?
 - What happens if nobody stops them?
- A villain does not need to be sympathetic, but they should generally be understandable. "Because they are evil" is rarely as interesting as a specific motive.
- Let the villains act! Do not keep important villains frozen in place until the player characters arrive. If the characters ignore a threat, the threat may advance.
- The villain might:
 - Recruit allies
 - Gain political influence
 - Acquire an artifact
 - Attack someone important
 - Relocate
 - Fortify a position
 - Complete part of a larger plan
 - Learn more about the player characters
- The world should react to the players' choices.
- Do not protect villains from the players! If the players devise a clever and plausible way to undermine, capture, expose, or even kill a major villain earlier than

expected, strongly consider letting it work (if appropriate).

ASSESSING PLAYER-DESIGNED ABILITIES:

- OSK gives players unusually broad authority to design their own mechanical abilities.
- The GM therefore has a responsibility to assess those Abilities before and during play. This assessment should be collaborative rather than adversarial!
- Your goal is not to search for reasons to reject an Ability. Your goal is to help the player express the character concept they want while keeping the Ability understandable, balanced, and compatible with the rest of the game.
- When reviewing an Ability, first ask: What is this Ability supposed to do? Then assess whether the card actually accomplishes that purpose cleanly.
- Consider questions such as:
 - Does it preserve the fantasy or function of its Source Ability?
 - Is the Source Ability appropriate for the character's Classes and approximate Level?
 - Does the card fit comfortably on a 3x5 card?
 - Can it be resolved quickly?
 - Are its Range, Targets, Damage, Duration, reliability, and secondary effects clearly defined?
 - Does it require Cooldown when appropriate?
 - Are its strongest benefits paired with meaningful limitations?
 - Does it trivialize a broad category of challenges?

- Does it undermine another player's specialty?
- Does it rewrite a core game system unnecessarily?
- Would the Ability still seem reasonably fair if an enemy used something similar against the players?
- Do not evaluate individual parameters in isolation. Judge the complete package.
- One Ability may have unusually high damage because it is short-range and unreliable; another may deal little or no damage because it inflicts a powerful condition.
- You do not need to perfectly predict how every Designed Ability will perform before approving it.
- Playtesting is part of design! Approve reasonable ideas in good faith and observe how they function during actual play.
- If an Ability proves substantially stronger, weaker, slower, stranger, or more disruptive than expected, revise it. Be sure to explain why.
- Whenever possible, preserve the part of the Ability the player actually cares about and adjust another parameter.
- For example, if a player's signature lightning blast is dealing too much damage because it also strikes six enemies at long range, reducing its Damage Tier is generally preferable to removing the lightning-blast fantasy entirely.
- If you believe a player's Ability only works because of an ambiguous interpretation, resolve that ambiguity directly.

- Do not allow the Ability and then secretly design every encounter to counter it. If a card is a problem....fix the card.

Chapter coming soon.